

West of Ireland Planting Guide

Your available materials: Clay soil · Multipurpose compost · Ericaceous compost · Horticultural bark · Horticultural grit · Small pebbles · Vermiculite · Perlite

DRAINAGE: YOUR MOST IMPORTANT RULE

West of Ireland clay soil is typically heavy, poorly draining, and mildly acidic to neutral (pH ~6.0–7.0). The Atlantic climate brings very high rainfall year-round. **The single most important thing you can do for the majority of these plants is improve drainage before planting.**

General clay soil recipe for most non-ericaceous plants: - Dig each planting hole at least twice the width and depth of the rootball - Mix the excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost - Add 20–30% horticultural grit by volume to that mix - After planting, mulch with horticultural bark (5–7cm), keeping mulch away from stems/crowns - Test your soil pH before planting — west of Ireland soils vary considerably

HOW TO USE YOUR MATERIALS

Material	Best Use
Clay soil	Base for all in-ground plantings
Multipurpose compost	Soil amendment for most plants (50/50 with clay)
Ericaceous compost	Blueberry · Heather · Lingonberry · Cranberry · Japanese Maple (partial) · Star Magnolia (partial) · Deer Fern · Hydrangea macrophylla (for blue flowers) · Japanese Skimmia · Dicksonia antarctica (partial) · Japanese Camellia · Prickly Heath
Horticultural bark	Surface mulch for all in-ground plants (5–7cm), keep away from stems
Horticultural grit	Drainage improver mixed into clay (20–30%); vital for rosemary, lavender, roses, peonies, pasqueflower, fritillaria, creeping juniper, dianthus, phlox subulata, bearded iris, dwarf iris, alliums, freesia, ixia, sempervivum, saxifrage, campanula saxifraga, edelweiss, auricula, siberian statice
Small pebbles	Base drainage layer in pots; decorative surface mulch for Mediterranean herbs and rock plants
Vermiculite	Seed-starting; mix into potting compost for moisture retention
Perlite	Drainage improver in pots (10–20%); especially for rosemary, lavender, blueberry, acidanthera, herbs

THE PLANTS

Groups: A = Ornamental Trees & Shrubs | B = Fruit Trees & Shrubs | C = Groundcover & Creeping Plants | D = Climbers & Wall Plants | E = Bulbs | F = Ornamental Perennials | G = Annual Flowers | H = Kitchen Herbs & Vegetables | I = Shade & Woodland Plants | J = Pond & Water Plants

GROUP A: ORNAMENTAL TREES & SHRUBS

A1. Bamboo (clump-forming: *Fargesia* spp., *Chusquea* spp.)

-  **Reference photo:** [Bamboo — view on Wikipedia](#)
- Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. *Fargesia* prefers some afternoon shade.
- Soil needs:** Most soils including clay; prefers moist, fertile, free-draining. Choose clump-forming species — running bamboo (*Phyllostachys*) requires a 60cm deep root barrier.
- Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix clay 50/50 with compost. Mulch well.
- Planting depth:** At pot level.
- Spacing:** 1.5–3m from structures; root barrier for running types
- Fertiliser:** High-nitrogen fertiliser (lawn feed or balanced granular) each spring. Top-dress with compost each autumn. Container plants: balanced liquid fertiliser monthly during the growing season.
- Companions:** Ferns, hostas, astilbe, hellebores. Bamboo provides shelter for smaller plants. Root barrier required near structures.

A2. Border Forsythia (*Forsythia* × *intermedia*)

-  **Reference photo:** [Border Forsythia — view on Wikipedia](#)
- Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. Flowers better in full sun.
- Soil needs:** pH 6.0–8.0. Tolerates clay very well.

Soil prep: Standard clay improvement with compost and grit.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1.5m between; 2m from walls

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser (Growmore) in early spring. Annual compost mulch after pruning. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds.
△ Prune immediately after flowering — never in autumn/winter (flower buds form on old wood).

Companions: Spring tulips underplanted, Vinca or Pulmonaria as underplanting, holly or yew as evergreen backdrop.

A3. Cherry Blossom ‘Kanzan’ (*Prunus* ‘Kanzan’)

 **Reference photo:** [Cherry Blossom ‘Kanzan’ — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun. Avoid frost pockets — late frosts damage April blossom.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: 60cm wide, 45cm deep. Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. Stake well.

Planting depth: Graft union at or just above soil level.

Spacing: 4–5m from trees/structures

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in early spring. Compost mulch around base each spring. Do not feed in late summer.

Companions: Daffodils and tulips beneath (spectacularly timed with April blossom). Forget-me-nots as blue-and-pink carpet. Hostas and hardy geraniums as underplanting.

A4. Common Hawthorn (*Crataegus monogyna*)

 **Reference photo:** [Common Hawthorn — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Very adaptable — most soils including heavy clay, chalk, and poor ground; pH 5.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — one of the most tolerant trees of clay and exposure. Improve drainage with grit only on the wettest sites.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: As hedge: 30–45cm; as tree: 4–6m from structures

Fertiliser: None needed once established. Light mulch of compost in early years.

Companions: Classic native hedgerow tree — combines with blackthorn, holly and hazel for a mixed native hedge; underplant with primroses, bluebells and violets.

West of Ireland: Ireland’s most familiar native hedgerow and windbreak tree (“whitethorn”), exceptionally tolerant of wind, salt spray and exposure — an excellent, low-cost choice for shelterbelts on Atlantic-facing boundaries. Masses of white May blossom followed by red autumn haws valuable for birds.

A5. Dwarf Lily Magnolia (*Magnolia liliiflora*, e.g. ‘Nigra’)

 **Reference photo:** [Dwarf Lily Magnolia — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ part shade, sheltered from cold wind.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; slightly acid to neutral, pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes shallow chalk and waterlogging.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30% compost/ericaceous compost and grit for drainage. Avoid deep planting.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; shallow, fleshy roots — do not disturb once planted.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants/structures

Fertiliser: Balanced or ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Annual mulch with compost or bark, kept away from the trunk.

Companions: Underplant with hellebores, ferns, snowdrops; pairs well with Japanese maple and star magnolia for a spring border.

West of Ireland: More compact and later-flowering than star magnolia, so its blooms often escape the worst late frosts. Reliably hardy in sheltered west of Ireland gardens; avoid frost pockets and exposed coastal wind.

A6. False Spirea (*Sorbaria sorbifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Sorbaria sorbifolia — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Most moist soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Very adaptable and tolerant of poor drainage better than many shrubs.

Soil prep: Minimal — dig hole twice rootball width, mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants; spreads by suckers

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Good at the back of a mixed border with hydrangea and deutzia; also useful for stabilising damp banks.

West of Ireland: Vigorous, suckering shrub with creamy plume-like flowers in summer — spreads readily by suckers, so best given room to naturalise (e.g. a bank or informal border) rather than a tight border, where it can be kept in check by removing suckers.

A7. Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester (*Deutzia scabra*)

 **Reference photo:** [Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Flowers best and stays more compact in full sun; needs a sheltered spot out of the coldest wind.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Not fussy once drainage is adequate.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1.5–2m between plants; grows 1.8–3m tall

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Lewis mock orange, lilac, weigela — classic spring/early-summer flowering shrub border. Underplant with spring bulbs.

West of Ireland: A larger, more vigorous *Deutzia* than the dwarf *D. gracilis* type, with distinctive peeling cinnamon-coloured bark and fuzzy, sandpaper-textured leaves (hence “scabra,” Latin for rough) that give this cultivar its common name. Double white flowers, sometimes tinged pink, in early summer on arching branches. Prune immediately after flowering, removing a proportion of the oldest stems at the base each year to keep it renewing well — it flowers on the previous year’s wood, so late pruning sacrifices next year’s display. Note: in parts of North America this species can self-seed and naturalise; in an Irish garden setting this is not generally a concern, but deadheading after flowering avoids any risk of unwanted seedlings.

A8. Holly (*Ilex aquifolium*)

 **Reference photo:** [Holly — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ● Full shade to ☀ full sun. Extraordinary adaptability. More berries in sunnier positions. ♂ Plant at least one male + one female for berries.

Soil needs: pH 4.5–8.0. Tolerates heavy clay, poor soil, coastal exposure.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice rootball size, backfill with clay/compost mix. Grit helpful but not essential.

Planting depth: At pot level; fibrous shallow root mat, do not bury deeply.

Spacing: 1.5–3m between; slow-growing hedge

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring only if plant looks weak or pale. Annual bark mulch more useful than heavy feeding. Container: slow-release granular fertiliser each spring, liquid feed monthly in summer.

Companions: Yew (classic Irish churchyard combination), forsythia (glows against dark foliage), winter-flowering hellebores, snowdrops beneath. Critical: plant at least one male (e.g. ‘Silver Queen’ — confusingly a male) and one or more berry-bearing females nearby (within 50–100m).

⚠ **All parts except berry flesh toxic to humans and livestock.**

A9. Irish Yew (*Taxus baccata* ‘Fastigiata’)

 **Reference photo:** [Irish Yew — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ● Full shade to ☀ full sun. Narrow column; produces more compact form in full sun. Discovered as natural mutation in Co. Fermanagh in the 18th century — all Irish yews worldwide descend from that one tree.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils, pH 5.0–8.0. Tolerates heavy clay if drainage adequate. Deeply dislikes waterlogged roots.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. On very wet clay, plant on a raised mound.

Planting depth: At pot level. Extensive but not deep root system.

Spacing: Column 1m wide eventually; 1m from structures

Fertiliser: Very little required. Light balanced slow-release fertiliser in spring if plant looks pale. Annual bark mulch more beneficial than chemical feeding. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds.

Companions: Holly, peonies, roses (as a dark backdrop), hellebores, snowdrops. Evergreen column provides structure year-round.

⚠ **All parts except red berry flesh are highly toxic to humans, horses and livestock. Do not plant near paddocks.**

A10. Japanese Camellia (*Camellia japonica*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Japanese Camellia — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade preferred, sheltered from early morning sun (which can damage frosted buds) and cold wind.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich, acid soil; pH 5.0–6.5. Will yellow (chlorosis) on alkaline soil.

Soil prep: Mix clay generously with ericaceous compost (40%+) and grit. In a container, use peat-free ericaceous compost.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; shallow-rooted, do not bury the stem base.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Ericaceous slow-release feed after flowering in spring. Avoid feeding after midsummer, to let wood ripen before winter.

Companions: Japanese skimmia, hydrangea macrophylla, Japanese maple — classic acid-soil shrub border.

West of Ireland: The mild, humid west of Ireland climate suits camellias well, though a sheltered spot out of early morning sun and harsh wind protects the flowers. Excellent in a large container of ericaceous compost if clay soil is not acid enough.

A11. Japanese Maple (*Acer palmatum*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Japanese Maple — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade preferred. Morning sun with afternoon shade is ideal. Variegated and dissectum types especially wind-sensitive. Avoid open exposed positions.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, slightly acidic, pH 5.5–6.5.

Soil prep: Dig 2–3× diameter of rootball. Mix clay with compost, 25% ericaceous compost and 25% grit in backfill. Shallow-rooted — do not dig deeply.

Planting depth: At pot level. Shallow-rooted; do not bury.

Spacing: 2–4m from structures; wind shelter essential

Fertiliser: Slow-release balanced fertiliser (e.g. Osmocote) in spring. Container: liquid feed monthly April–July at balanced rate — do not feed after July. Annual composted bark mulch.

Companions: Hostas (classic combination), ferns, hellebores, snowdrops beneath. Excellent specimen plant. Avoid planting with other thirsty trees nearby.

West of Ireland: Wind shelter is essential. Sheltered courtyard or walled garden position is ideal.

A12. Japanese Skimmia (*Skimmia japonica*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Japanese Skimmia — view source](#)

Light: ● Shade to ☁ partial shade preferred; tolerates full sun in cooler, moister climates like the west of Ireland.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; prefers slightly acid to neutral, pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes dry or chalky soils.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost and grit for drainage. Add well-rotted organic matter.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark; shallow-rooted, do not bury the stem base.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants; ♂+♀ within a few metres for berries

Fertiliser: Ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Mulch annually with ericaceous compost or bark.

Companions: Hellebores, ferns, hostas and other shade/woodland plants; Japanese maple and hydrangea for a shaded border.

West of Ireland: Dioecious — plant at least one male (e.g. ‘Rubella’) near females (e.g. ‘Nymans’) for the females’ red berries. Compact, reliable evergreen for shaded, sheltered spots; good in containers on the north side of a house.

⚠ Berries are mildly toxic if ingested in quantity.

A13. Lewis Mock Orange (*Philadelphus lewisii*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lewis Mock Orange — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ part shade. Best flowering and fragrance in full sun.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of a wide range once established.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1.5–2m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds, which favour leaves over flowers.

Companions: Deutzia and Lilac (classic mixed shrub border companions), roses, spring bulbs beneath.

West of Ireland: State flower of Idaho, very hardy and wind-tolerant once established — a good choice for exposed Atlantic gardens. Prune immediately after flowering (flowers on previous year's wood).

A14. Lilac (*Syringa vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lilac — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — needs at least 6 hours to flower well.

Soil needs: Neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–8.0.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–25% grit. Add garden lime if soil is acidic. Slight mound if waterlogging is a risk.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1.5m between; 2m from walls

Fertiliser: Superphosphate or balanced fertiliser in early spring. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds (produces leaves, not flowers). Annual compost mulch around base.

Companions: Roses (May–June combination), alliums, irises, peonies, delphiniums, aquilegia, geraniums. Foxgloves self-seed naturally nearby.

A15. Mophead / Lacecap Hydrangea (*Hydrangea macrophylla*)

 **Reference photo:** [Hydrangea macrophylla — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade preferred. Morning sun with afternoon shade is ideal. Bigleaf hydrangea performs best in areas with dappled sunlight, partial shade, or deep shade. Protect it from afternoon sun. The macrophylla cultivars famously tolerate coastal exposure.

Soil needs: They love a fertile, humus-rich, clay soil. pH 5.0–6.0 for blue flowers; 6.0–7.0 for pink flowers. Moist but well-drained. Good salt tolerance. Flower colour changes depending on soil pH — blue in acid soils (high aluminium availability), mauve in lightly acid to neutral soil, pink in alkaline conditions.

Soil prep: Before planting, dig in well-rotted compost or manure to the whole area (not just the planting hole), using a bucketful per square yard/metre. Make the planting hole as deep as the root ball and three times wider. For blue flowers: use ericaceous compost in the planting hole and grow in ericaceous compost in containers.

Planting depth: At pot level; place the top of the rootball at or slightly above surrounding soil level. Shallow-rooted — avoid hoeing around it as roots can be easily damaged.

Spacing: 90cm–2.4m between (check label for variety size)

Fertiliser: Fertilise once in spring with a fertiliser designed to encourage blooms such as one high in phosphorus (e.g. 15-30-15). For blue flowers: feed with a fertiliser low in phosphorus and high in potassium and use ericaceous compost. If you're gardening on alkaline soils and want to retain blue flowers, grow in containers using ericaceous compost. Stop feeding after August.

⚠ **Pruning note:** Hydrangeas that flower on old wood should not be pruned hard as you will lose this summer's flowers. Prune in mid-spring; only remove the withered flowerheads and dead parts. Traditionally leave old flowers on through winter to protect new growth from cold.

Companions: Astilbe, hostas, ferns (all love similar moist, semi-shaded conditions). Yarrow pairs beautifully with hydrangea. Heucheras, hardy geraniums, and hellebores as underplanting. Behind low-growing perennials such as bergenia at the border front.

Pot size: Standard mophead varieties reach 1–1.5m in containers and need 50–60cm pots at maturity. Compact cultivars like Cityline Paris manage in 30–35cm pots. Use ericaceous compost for blue flowers; standard John Innes No.3 (2 parts) + multipurpose compost (1 part) for pink flowers.

West of Ireland: Hydrangeas are one of the quintessential plants of Irish gardens. Macrophylla hydrangeas tolerate coastal exposure too. The mild, moist Atlantic climate suits them perfectly. The west of Ireland's naturally slightly acidic soils tend to produce beautiful blue-mauve flowers. Choose a sheltered spot away from frost pockets — late frosts can damage new growth.

A16. Mountain Ash / Rowan (*Sorbus aucuparia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Mountain Ash / Rowan — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Very adaptable — most soils including clay, acid or neutral; pH 5.0–7.0. Dislikes shallow chalk.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost; grit if drainage is poor.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 3–5m from structures

Fertiliser: Little required once established. Balanced feed in the first two seasons; annual compost mulch.

Companions: A traditional companion to holly and hawthorn in native hedgerows and gardens; underplant with ferns, foxgloves, hellebores.

West of Ireland: One of the hardiest, most wind- and exposure-tolerant native trees, traditionally planted near Irish homes for protection (“the traveller’s tree” / rowan folklore). Bright orange-red berries from late summer are an important food source for birds; excellent for exposed sites.

A17. St John’s Wort ‘Rowallane’ (*Hypericum ‘Rowallane’*)

 **Reference photo:** [Hypericum ‘Rowallane’ — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ part shade. Flowers best in full sun.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Prefers shelter from hard frost and cold winds — borderline hardy (RHS H4), so a sheltered spot is important in the west of Ireland.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual compost mulch; avoid feeding late in the season, which can soften growth ahead of winter.

Companions: Heathers, skimmia and other evergreen structure shrubs; also pairs well with roses and late perennials for a long season of interest.

West of Ireland: Large, showy golden-yellow flowers from midsummer into autumn. Semi-evergreen to evergreen in mild areas. Site against a warm wall or in a sheltered border, away from the coldest exposure.

A18. Star Magnolia (*Magnolia stellata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Star Magnolia — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade. Morning sun, sheltered position. Blooms in March–April — susceptible to late frost damage.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, pH 5.0–6.5. Tolerates alkaline better than most magnolias (RHS). Shallow, fleshy roots — handle gently.

Soil prep: Wide, shallow hole. Mix clay with compost and 20% grit. Generous bark or leaf mould mulch each spring.

Planting depth: At pot level. Do not plant deeper. Fleshy roots are fragile — do not damage.

Spacing: 2.5m spread; shelter from N/E winds

Fertiliser: Slow-release balanced fertiliser in spring. Annual bark mulch more beneficial than heavy feeding. Ericaceous liquid feed sparingly on acidic soils.

Companions: Snowdrops, species crocus, Iris reticulata (bloom before magnolia leafs up). Hellebores in partial shade beneath. Hardy geraniums as ground cover. White flowers shown off beautifully against evergreen backdrop.

GROUP B: FRUIT TREES & SHRUBS

B1. Apple Tree ‘Baya Marisa’ on P22 Rootstock (*Malus domestica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Apple Tree ‘Baya Marisa’ on P22 Rootstock — view on Wikipedia](#)

About P22: A Polish rootstock (M.9 × Common Antonovka cross). Ultimate height 2–3m; width 100–125cm at maturity; fruits September–October. Requires permanent staking for life. Good resistance to root rots (a key advantage on Irish clay). Harvest September–October (per gardens4you.ie listing).

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily.

Soil needs: Well-drained, moderately fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Good root rot resistance on wet clay.

Soil prep: Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost over a broad area. Keep a 60cm weed-free circle around the base permanently.

Planting depth: Graft union (bulge near stem base) at or just above soil level. Plant to the nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between trees; permanent stake

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) each February. Liquid high-potash feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from late spring to midsummer. Do not feed after July. Bonemeal in the planting hole at planting.

Companions: Chives and garlic deter aphids (P22 is susceptible to woolly apple aphid). Nasturtiums attract beneficial insects. Plant two or more apple varieties for cross-pollination.

West of Ireland: Permanent staking essential against Atlantic winds.

B2. Blackberries (*Rubus fruticosus* agg.)

 **Reference photo:** [Blackberries — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade for best fruiting.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.0. One of the most clay-tolerant fruiting plants.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants against wires

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser (Growmore) in spring. Annual mulch with compost.

Companions: Raspberries and other cane fruit with similar needs; avoid planting near wild bramble, which can cross-pollinate and revert vigour.

West of Ireland: Extremely easy and productive on Irish clay — thornless cultivars (e.g. ‘Loch Ness’, ‘Oregon Thornless’) are more manageable than wild bramble for a garden setting. Provide a sturdy wire support and tie in new canes each summer; cut back fruited canes after harvest.

B3. Blackcurrant (*Ribes nigrum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Blackcurrant — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade — tolerates shade better than other currants.

Soil prep: Double dig; compost generously; 15–20% grit on heavy clay.

Planting depth: 5–7cm deeper than nursery mark. Cut all stems to 10cm after planting.

Spacing: 1.2–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: High-nitrogen fertiliser in early spring. Again after harvest. Generous compost or manure mulch each winter. Potassium deficiency (brown leaf edges) common — use balanced feed with potassium.

Companions: Alliums, garlic, nasturtiums nearby; redcurrant, gooseberry in the same bed.

B4. Blueberry (*Vaccinium corymbosum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Blueberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade. More berries in full sun.

Soil needs: Ericaceous, pH 4.0–5.5. Use ericaceous compost only. Rainwater preferred for watering.

Pot size: Start in 40cm diameter pot; scale up every 2–3 years. Final container: minimum 50 litres (~60cm diameter, 45–60cm deep). One blueberry per pot. Heather and lingonberry compatible at edges of a wide trough (same pH).

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1 plant per pot; 60cm between pots

Fertiliser: Use only ericaceous liquid fertiliser fortnightly April–August. Top-dress with fresh ericaceous compost in spring. Sulphur chips to maintain acidity over time.

Companions: Heather, lingonberry, cranberry, other *Vaccinium*. Dedicated ericaceous bed with rhododendrons and azaleas if naturally acidic area.

B5. Cranberry (*Vaccinium macrocarpon*)

 **Reference photo:** [Cranberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Best fruiting in full sun.

Soil needs: Highly acidic, pH 4.0–5.0. Bog plant — prefers consistently moist, peaty, acidic conditions. Must be grown in ericaceous compost container or purpose-made acidic bog bed.

Pot size: 30–45cm wide, 20–30cm deep container; 100% ericaceous compost. Keep consistently moist. Do not add grit.

Planting depth: At pot level; shallow-rooting.

Spacing: 30–45cm in acidic bed

Fertiliser: Ericaceous liquid fertiliser monthly April–August. Do not use general-purpose fertilisers. Adapted to nutrient-poor conditions — do not overfeed.

Companions: Heather, lingonberry, blueberry (all share ericaceous requirements). Low carpet beneath taller blueberry bushes.

West of Ireland: The moist, mild Atlantic climate is naturally ideal for cranberry — but only if you provide or replicate acidic bog soil. Container with ericaceous compost is most practical.

B6. Garden Plum (*Prunus domestica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Garden Plum — view source](#)

Light: ✨ Full sun essential for best fruiting — at least 6 hours daily, sheltered from wind.

Soil needs: Well-drained, moderately fertile soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay — good drainage is essential.

Soil prep: Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit over a broad area. Keep a weed-free circle around the base.

Planting depth: Graft union (bulge near stem base) at or just above soil level. Plant to the nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 3–5m between trees depending on rootstock; permanent stake

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) each February. Do not feed after midsummer, to allow wood to ripen before winter. Potash feed helps fruiting.

Companions: Chives and garlic to deter aphids. Comfrey or nasturtiums nearby to attract beneficial insects. Many plums (though not all) need a compatible pollination partner flowering at the same time — check the variety before buying.

West of Ireland: Permanent staking recommended against Atlantic winds, especially on dwarfing rootstocks. Choose a sheltered, sunny spot away from frost pockets — plum blossoms early and late frosts can damage the crop.

B7. Gooseberry (*Ribes uva-crispa*)

 **Reference photo:** [Gooseberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Tolerates semi-shade better than most fruit.

Soil prep: Compost and grit amendment. Bonemeal at planting.

Planting depth: At nursery mark; roots covered ~5cm. Cut all stems to 30cm after planting.

Spacing: 1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Sulphate of potash in late winter/early spring. Balanced fertiliser after flowering. Annual compost mulch. Avoid excessive nitrogen.

Companions: Redcurrants, whitecurrants. Tansy nearby reportedly repels gooseberry sawfly.

B8. Honeyberry (*Lonicera caerulea* var. *kamtschatica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Honeyberry — Kamchatka — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Fruits better in full sun.

Soil needs: Very flexible, pH 4.5–7.5, tolerates clay. Plant two different varieties for cross-pollination.

Soil prep: Standard clay improvement with compost and grit.

Planting depth: At pot level or slightly deeper.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch. Liquid balanced feed monthly during flowering and fruiting can improve yields.

Companions: Blueberry, lingonberry in adjacent beds. Pollinator-attracting flowers nearby (important for early February–April flowers). Needs 2+ varieties: e.g. ‘Borealis’ and ‘Tundra’.

B9. Lingonberry (*Vaccinium vitis-idaea*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lingonberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade preferred — woodland edge as recommended by the RHS. Tolerates full sun if soil stays consistently moist.

Soil needs: Acidic, moist but well-drained, pH 4.2–5.5. Same requirements as blueberry. Will not tolerate neutral or alkaline soil.

Pot size: 30cm diameter, 20cm+ deep container; 100% ericaceous compost. Or a dedicated acidic bed.

Planting depth: At pot level. Space 30cm apart.

Spacing: 30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Ericaceous liquid fertiliser monthly April–August only. Mulch with pine bark to maintain acidity.

Companions: Blueberry, heather, cranberry. Low ground cover under taller blueberry bushes. Also combines well with deer fern (same acidic conditions) in a naturalistic ericaceous bed.

West of Ireland: Produces berries twice per year (late July and late September). Self-fertile. Excellent for west of Ireland mild, moist climate.

B10. Pomegranate (*Punica granatum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Pomegranate — view source](#)

Light: ✨ Full sun essential, against a warm, sheltered south- or west-facing wall.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width against the wall base. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–3m against wall; borderline hardy, best in a container

Fertiliser: Balanced fruit tree fertiliser in spring. Liquid high-potash feed through summer to encourage flowering/fruiting.

Companions: Other wall-trained sun-lovers such as passiflora or grapevine on the same warm wall.

West of Ireland: Borderline hardy (RHS H4, roughly to –5 to –10°C) — reliable fruiting in the west of Ireland’s cooler, shorter summers is uncertain, and pomegranate is best treated primarily as an ornamental flowering wall shrub here, grown against a warm wall or in a large container that can be moved under cover in winter, with any fruit a bonus rather than a certainty.

B11. Raspberry (*Rubus idaeus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Raspberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade. Better fruiting in full sun.

Soil prep: Compost and grit essential on clay. Raised bed recommended.

Planting depth: Crown 5–7cm below soil. Cut canes to 25cm after planting.

Spacing: 45–60cm between canes; 1.8m between rows

Fertiliser: High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) fortnightly from spring bud break until fruit set. Or balanced granular fertiliser in early spring plus compost mulch. Avoid excessive nitrogen on wet clay.

Companions: Garlic, marigolds, tansy deter aphids. Avoid planting near potatoes (shared virus diseases) and wild brambles.

B12. Redcurrant (*Ribes rubrum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Redcurrant — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade. One of the most shade-tolerant fruiting plants — good for north-facing fences trained as a fan.

Soil prep: Compost and grit amendment. Good drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery mark; roots covered ~5cm.

Spacing: 1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Sulphate of potash in late winter. Balanced fertiliser after flowering. Annual bark or compost mulch. Do not overfeed with nitrogen.

Companions: Gooseberries, whitecurrants. North-facing fan trained redcurrant is a remarkably productive use of otherwise difficult wall space.

B13. Rhubarb (*Rheum × hybridum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Rhubarb — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌙 partial shade. Tolerates partial shade better than most vegetables.

Soil needs: Fertile, moisture-retentive but well-drained. RHS advises raised beds on heavy clay.

Soil prep: Remove weeds, dig in two bucketfuls of compost per sq metre. Raised bed (30cm+) on wet clay.

Planting depth: Buds 1–2cm below soil level.

Spacing: 90cm between crowns

Fertiliser: Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. Generous well-rotted manure or compost mulch each autumn after leaves die back — this is the most beneficial treatment.

Companions: Beans and peas nearby (nitrogen-fixers). Keep away from fennel (inhibits many plants). Do not pick in the first year after planting.

B14. Serviceberry (*Amelanchier lamarckii*)

 **Reference photo:** [Serviceberry — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌙 part shade. Best autumn colour in full sun.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; tolerates acid to neutral, pH 5.5–7.0. Dislikes waterlogging.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width and as deep as the rootball. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 2–4m between plants/structures

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost or bark mulch; little further feeding needed once established.

Companions: Underplant with hellebores, snowdrops, bluebells and ferns; works well as a woodland-edge specimen with Japanese maple and hydrangea.

West of Ireland: Multi-season interest — white spring blossom, edible summer berries (loved by birds), fiery autumn colour. Tolerates coastal wind well once established.

B15. Strawberry (*Fragaria × ananassa*)

 **Reference photo:** [Strawberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for maximum fruiting.

Soil needs: pH 5.5–6.8, well-drained. Raised bed on clay strongly recommended.

Soil prep: Compost and grit. Raised bed 20–25cm high.

Planting depth: Crown exactly at soil level — too deep = crown rot; too shallow = roots dry out.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) fortnightly from first flowers until fruiting ceases. Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. Do not use high-nitrogen fertiliser.

Companions: Borage, garlic, chives, marigolds. Avoid planting near brassicas.

B16. Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia' (*Prunus avium* 'Sylvia')

 **Reference photo:** [Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia' — view source](#)

About 'Sylvia': A compact, self-fertile sweet cherry suitable for patios and smaller gardens. Mature height approximately 125–150cm with a spread of 30–40cm, making it one of the most compact cherries available — well suited to container growing (source: gardens4you.ie).

Light: ☀ Full sun to 🌙 partial sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil.

Soil prep: Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30%

grit for drainage.

Planting depth: Approximately 12cm, or to the nursery soil mark/graft union at or just above soil level.

Spacing: 1m spacing; self-fertile

Fertiliser: Feed from spring until fruit sets, and again after harvest. Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed).

Companions: Chives and garlic to deter aphids. Keep an area of roughly 1.2m around the base weed-free and mulched.

Pruning: Best pruned in summer, ideally straight after harvest, to reduce the risk of silver leaf disease common to *Prunus* species.

West of Ireland: Self-fertile, so a single tree will produce fruit — ideal for smaller west of Ireland gardens or patios. Harvest June–July. White blossom in spring. Permanent staking recommended given its compact form and Atlantic winds.

B17. Woodland Strawberry (*Fragaria vesca*)

 **Reference photo:** [Woodland Strawberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Tolerates full shade but fruits less freely there.

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Tolerates clay and a wide pH range better than most fruit.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost. Mulch with leaf mould to mimic its natural woodland-edge habitat.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level — do not bury the crown.

Spacing: 25–30cm between plants; runners will fill gaps and can be left to spread or removed to keep a tidier clump.

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch, kept away from the crown.

Companions: Ferns, hostas, primroses — a natural, decorative groundcover under fruit trees and in a woodland-edge bed; also good as informal edging along a path.

West of Ireland: Smaller and less showy than garden strawberry, but reliably hardy, shade-tolerant and long-fruited (often June to autumn), with small, intensely flavoured berries. Spreads gently by runners to form an attractive edible groundcover under trees and shrubs — a good choice for a spot too shaded for garden strawberry.

GROUP C: GROUNDCOVER & CREEPING PLANTS

C1. Creeping Juniper (*Juniperus horizontalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Creeping Juniper — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — cannot grow in shade.

Soil needs: pH 4.5–8.5. Tolerates clay, rocky and poor soils. Requires excellent drainage — will rot in constantly wet clay.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30–40% horticultural grit. Plant on a slight mound or raised bed. Raised bed on very wet clay.

Planting depth: At pot level or slightly raised above it.

Spacing: 1–1.5m for ground cover

Fertiliser: Virtually no feeding required — evolved on lean soils. Light slow-release balanced fertiliser in spring only if plant appears weak. Grit mulch more beneficial than fertiliser.

Companions: Heather, sedum, ornamental grasses, thyme, rosemary. Excellent ground cover beneath Irish yew, holly and conifers. Good companion for fruit trees.

West of Ireland: ⚠ The biggest challenge is the region's high rainfall. Raised beds, slopes, or very well-drained gritty ground are essential.

C2. Creeping Phlox / Moss Phlox (*Phlox subulata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Phlox subulata — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun preferred. Creeping Phlox thrives in full sun, but it can tolerate light shade, especially in hotter climates. More sun typically leads to a denser bloom.

Soil needs: This plant prefers well-drained soil. While it can tolerate a range of soil types, from sandy to clay, it doesn't like to sit in water. Consider amending your soil with compost or other organic matter to improve drainage, especially if your soil is heavy clay. pH 5.5–7.7.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–25% grit. On heavy clay, a raised bed or slope is ideal.

Planting depth: At pot level. Plant Phlox subulata root balls so that the root system is fully submerged in the compost, leaving any young shoots/leaves, buds or stems exposed above the soil surface. Space 30–45cm apart.

Spacing: 30–45cm for ground cover

Fertiliser: In early spring, feed Creeping Phlox with a slow-release, balanced fertilizer to support healthy growth and abundant flowering. Light feeding only — over-feeding produces lush, floppy growth. Minimal fertiliser once established.

Companions: Creeping Phlox makes a gorgeous underplanting for spring bulbs like tulips and daffodils. Excellent on slopes, in rock gardens, or cascading over walls. With thyme, sedum, dianthus, and other well-drained-soil companions in a sunny rockery. Weigela as a taller backdrop.

Pot size: 20-30cm diameter, 15cm deep; multipurpose compost with 20-25% grit. Excellent in shallow, wide terracotta bowls on sunny patios.

West of Ireland: The mild, moist Irish climate requires excellent drainage for this plant. A sunny south-facing slope, raised bed, or rock garden is ideal. Grows well in walls and between paving stones. May suffer crown rot in continuously wet conditions — drainage is the key.

C3. Heather (*Calluna vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Heather — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ✱ Full sun — grow in well-drained, acidic soil in full sun. Calluna dislike alkaline soils, wet soils and shady areas, but tolerate light shade from high-canopied trees.

Soil needs: Calluna need neutral to acidic growing conditions — pH of 6.5 or less, ideally 5.5. They prefer light sandy soil, enriched with organic matter such as leafmould, well-composted pine needles or composted pine bark. If clay soil is heavy or alkaline, growing in containers with ericaceous compost is strongly recommended.

Soil prep: For in-ground planting on acidic soil: add leafmould, composted bark, and 20-25% grit to the clay. For neutral to alkaline clay: grow in containers only. Do not add lime near heather.

Planting depth: At pot level. Space 30-45cm apart.

Spacing: 30-45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Apply an ericaceous fertiliser annually in March/April to keep them flowering well, or use a liquid feed such as Phostrogen between April and September. Heather grown in fertile soil will generally not require feeding. For heather in pots, feed with an ericaceous fertiliser annually in March or April. Annual mulch with composted pine bark or leafmould.

Companions: Blueberry, lingonberry, cranberry (all ericaceous, sharing identical requirements). Creeping juniper. Deer fern. In the wider garden, heather combines beautifully with Japanese maple for contrasting textures, and with ornamental grasses. They look great planted with other mat-forming heathers such as Erica species, and dwarf bulbs. Planted with dwarf bulbs (species crocus, snowdrops) for year-round interest.

Pot size: Calluna can be grown in containers using peat-free ericaceous compost, and will suit whatever size garden or space you have available. Minimum 20-25cm diameter, 20cm deep; ericaceous compost; repot every 3 years.

West of Ireland: Heather is native to Irish heathlands and mountains and is perfectly adapted to the climate, especially the moist western conditions. Note that the naturally slightly acid to neutral soils of the west are often suitable for heather in-ground, but check your soil pH first. Erica tetralix (cross-leaved heath) is particularly at home in the wet western bogs and gives year-round interest alongside Calluna.

C4. Houseleek (*Sempervivum* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Sempervivum — view source](#)

Light: ✱ Full sun.

Soil needs: Very free-draining, poor to moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0-7.5. Rots quickly in wet clay, especially winter.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 40%+ grit, or grow entirely in a shallow pot/trough of gritty, free-draining compost.

Planting depth: At pot level; do not bury the rosette.

Spacing: 10-15cm between rosettes

Fertiliser: None to very little required — rich soil produces soft, less hardy growth.

Companions: Saxifrage, wall pennywort, thyme, sedum — classic gritty rockery/roof-garden planting.

West of Ireland: Extremely hardy and drought-tolerant once established, but the biggest risk on Irish clay is winter wet, not cold — a raised trough, wall top, or gritty rockery gives much better results than open ground. Spreads by offsets (“chicks”) to form a mat over time.

C5. Periwinkle (*Vinca minor* and *V. major*)

 **Reference photo:** [Periwinkle — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ● Full shade to ✱ full sun. Grow in any but very dry soil, in full sun (for best flowering) to partial shade.

Soil needs: Grow in any but very dry soil. Tolerates heavy clay, pH 5.5-8.0. One of the most clay-tolerant ground cover plants. Remarkably adaptable.

Soil prep: Basic compost addition to planting hole. Even unamended clay is usually tolerated.

Planting depth: At pot level. Space 30–45cm apart for ground cover.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; can spread

Fertiliser: Very low-maintenance. A balanced slow-release fertiliser in spring if the plant appears slow or pale. Annual bark mulch is more useful than feeding. In containers, monthly balanced liquid feed during the growing season.

Companions: Hellebores, snowdrops, ivy — classic trio for difficult shaded areas. Excellent under trees and shrubs where grass won't grow. Underplant forsythia, lilac, or shrub roses with periwinkle for year-round ground cover. The blue flowers of *V. minor* are a valuable early source of nectar for bees.

△ *Vinca* can spread vigorously — in small or formal gardens, divide and restrict regularly.

Pot size: 25–35cm diameter container; multipurpose compost.

West of Ireland: Excellent in all Irish conditions. Tolerates coastal exposure, clay, shade, and wet winters. Very low-maintenance once established. Can self-layer (roots where stems touch soil) and spread into extensive ground cover without any effort.

C6. Prickly Heath (*Gaultheria mucronata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Prickly Heath — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, acid soil; pH 4.5–6.0. Dislikes lime.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost and grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants; ♂+♀ for berries

Fertiliser: Ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Annual mulch with ericaceous compost or bark.

Companions: Heather, blueberry, lingonberry — classic acid-soil groundcover planting; good with dwarf conifers.

West of Ireland: Dioecious — plant a male near females for the females' showy, long-lasting white, pink or magenta berries in autumn/winter. Compact evergreen groundcover, tolerant of coastal exposure once established.

C7. Reindeer Lichen (*Cladonia rangiferina*)

 **Reference photo:** [Reindeer Lichen — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Very poor, free-draining, acid soil or bare mineral ground/rock; pH 4.0–5.5. Will not survive in rich garden soil or where it is shaded out by faster-growing plants.

Soil prep: None — this is a slow-growing lichen, not a rooted vascular plant. Best established on an existing patch of poor, undisturbed acid ground, sand, or a rockery, not planted into amended clay.

Planting depth: Laid on the surface, not buried.

Spacing: Establishes slowly; avoid disturbance

Fertiliser: None — feeding kills lichens, which take all their nutrients from air and rain.

Companions: Heather, sempervivum and other poor-soil, sun-loving plants of open heath or rockery.

West of Ireland: Genuinely difficult to establish deliberately — reindeer lichen grows extremely slowly (a few mm per year) and needs open, undisturbed, nutrient-poor ground, most realistically an established rockery or heath-style planting rather than a conventional border. Best treated as a feature to preserve if already present, rather than one to plant and expect quick results from.

C8. Saxifrage (*Saxifraga* spp., alpine/rockery types)

 **Reference photo:** [Saxifrage — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade, depending on species.

Soil needs: Free-draining, gritty soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Most alpine saxifrages rot in wet, heavy clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 30–40% grit; best in a rockery, trough, or raised bed.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required. Light balanced feed in spring for container-grown plants.

Companions: Sempervivum, campanula saxifraga, wall pennywort, dwarf bulbs (species crocus, dwarf iris).

West of Ireland: A large genus with many hardy mat- and cushion-forming evergreen species suited to rockeries, troughs and wall crevices; excellent drainage is the single most important factor for success on west of Ireland clay.

C9. Trailing Rock Bellflower (*Campanula saxifraga*)

 **Reference photo:** [Campanula saxifraga — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining, gritty soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Rots in wet, heavy clay over winter.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 30–40% grit; best in a raised trough, rockery or wall crevice rather than open ground.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required. Light balanced feed in spring if in a container.

Companions: Sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort and other rockery/trough plants with the same sharp-drainage needs.

West of Ireland: A trailing, semi-evergreen alpine bellflower for troughs, rockeries or dry stone walls — best given the sharp drainage a raised trough or wall crevice provides, since it is one of the plants most likely to fail on flat, wet clay.

C10. Wall Pennywort (*Umbilicus rupestris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Wall Pennywort — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial to full shade; tolerates some sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining, near-neutral, gritty soil, often rooting in very little soil at all; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — this native succulent naturally colonises old stone walls, rock crevices and dry-stone boundaries. In a border, improve clay with grit; it is otherwise best established directly into a wall crevice or dry-stone gap with a little compost.

Planting depth: At pot level, or tucked into a wall crevice.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Ivy, ferns and other wall/shade plants at the base of old walls; sempervivum and saxifrage on drier wall tops.

West of Ireland: Common throughout Ireland on damp, shaded stone walls, banks and tree bases — an easy, attractive native succulent for softening an old wall or boundary; young leaves are edible in salads with a mild, slightly salty-cucumber flavour.

GROUP D: CLIMBERS & WALL PLANTS

D1. Blue Passion Flower (*Passiflora caerulea*)

 **Reference photo:** [Passiflora \(Blue Passion Flower\) — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun, sheltered from cold wind — a south- or west-facing wall is ideal.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Good drainage is essential — this is the hardest passion flower but still dislikes waterlogged roots in winter.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice the rootball width against the wall base. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit.

Planting depth: At nursery soil mark, 30–45cm from the wall, angled towards support.

Spacing: 2–3m between plants against wall/fence

Fertiliser: Balanced general or high-potash liquid feed monthly through the growing season. Avoid excess nitrogen, which favours leaf growth over flowers.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis and honeysuckle on the same wall/structure for a long season of colour.

West of Ireland: RHS hardiness H4 (hardy to about –5 to –10°C) — reliably hardy in most west of Ireland gardens with wall shelter, though may be cut back by hard frost and regrow from the base. Needs a sturdy support (trellis or wires) to climb by tendrils.

D2. Clematis (*Clematis* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Clematis — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Roots prefer shade (cover with stone or tile), stems flower best in sun or dappled light. Evergreen types prefer sheltered, sunny, south-facing wall.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile, neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost plus 20% grit. Shade the root zone.

Planting depth: Groups 2 & 3 large-flowered: 10–15cm DEEPER than pot; *C. montana* (Group 1): 8–10cm; Evergreen types: at pot level only.

Spacing: 60–90cm between; cool roots essential

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring. From April: high-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly until August. Feed regularly — clematis are hungry. Do not feed after August.

Companions: Climbing roses on the same wall (classic combination). Clematis through other shrubs. Late-flowering Group 3 through roses for second flush of colour.

D3. Climbing Honeysuckle (*Lonicera periclymenum*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Climbing Honeysuckle — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade. Woodland-edge habit: roots shaded, stems growing into light.

Soil needs: Most soils; prefers moist, humus-rich.

Soil prep: Hole the same size as rootball. Mix in compost. Firm in and mulch.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced general fertiliser in spring (Growmore) or manure mulch. Liquid tomato feed fortnightly in summer encourages flowering. Avoid excessive nitrogen.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis (classic combination). Plant near windows or doorways for evening fragrance. Native woodbine is a superb wildlife plant.

D4. Climbing Hydrangea (*Hydrangea anomala* subsp. *petiolaris*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Climbing Hydrangea — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ● to ☁ North or east-facing walls are ideal — will grow and flower in shade that defeats most climbers. Full sun tolerated if soil stays consistently moist. Self-clinging via aerial roots; slow to start but ultimately vigorous (can reach 10–15m). RHS hardiness rating: H5 (to -15°C).

Soil needs: Fertile, moist but well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Tolerates clay, loamy and sandy soils. Dislikes waterlogged or excessively dry conditions.

Soil prep: Dig hole twice as wide and the same depth as the rootball. Mix in compost. If against a wall or fence, allow a 45cm gap between plant and wall (rain shadow). Mulch well. Space 60cm+ between plants.

Planting depth: At pot level. Can tolerate slightly deeper planting as it forms shoot-like roots on buried stem.

Spacing: 45cm from wall; 60cm+ between plants

Fertiliser: Needs little feeding for the first three years — do not feed during establishment. After year three: balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring if leaves appear yellow; otherwise a single spring application of balanced granular feed is sufficient. Annual mulch with compost in late summer. Low-maintenance overall.

Companions: Grows beautifully with ivy on north-facing walls for year-round coverage. Ferns at its base (same moisture preference). Shade-tolerant hostas and hellebores beneath. Invaluable for dark walls where most climbers fail.

West of Ireland: Exceptional plant for the Irish climate. One of the very few climbers that genuinely thrives on cold, north-facing or shaded walls. The moist Atlantic climate suits it perfectly. Slow in the first 2–3 years but can ultimately cover an entire house wall.

D5. Climbing Roses (*Rosa*, climbing cultivars)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Climbing Roses — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ✨ Full sun preferred — at least 6 hours.

Soil needs: Fertile, well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Never plant where a rose previously grew.

Soil prep: Double-dig (50–60cm deep). Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. Position at least 45cm from wall.

Planting depth: Graft union just below soil level.

Spacing: 45cm from wall; 2–3m between plants

Fertiliser: Specialist rose fertiliser in late March and again in early June. Liquid high-potash feed fortnightly May–August. Stop feeding by late August. Annual bark or manure mulch.

Companions: Clematis (trained together on the same wall). Lavender at base. Alliums, salvia, hardy geraniums as foreground.

D6. Hardy Grapes (*Vitis vinifera*)

 **Reference photo:** [Hardy Grapes — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — south-facing wall essential. Without maximum sun, fruit will not ripen.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.0–6.5.

Soil prep: Clay/compost/grit plus coarse gravel at base. At least 20cm from wall.

Planting depth: At pot depth; graft above soil.

Spacing: 1.2–1.5m between vines; 20cm from wall

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser with potassium in early spring. High-potash liquid feed fortnightly through summer. Do not overfeed with nitrogen. Grapevines on somewhat lean soil often fruit better.

Companions: Lavender, rosemary, garlic, hyssop at base. Choose early, disease-resistant varieties (Boskoop Glory, Regent, Solaris). Good air circulation is critical in Irish conditions.

D7. Hops (*Humulus lupulus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Hops — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Full sun produces more vigorous growth and larger cones.

Soil needs: Rich, moist, well-drained, pH 6.0–8.0. Tolerates clay well.

Soil prep: Dig and enrich generously with compost. Heavy feeders.

Planting depth: Rhizome 5–8cm deep; pot-grown plants at pot level.

Spacing: 1–1.5m between plants

Fertiliser: High-nitrogen fertiliser in spring, then balanced fertiliser with potassium once flowering begins. Thick compost or manure mulch each spring. Container: balanced liquid feed monthly throughout the growing season.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis, ornamental grasses. Golden hop ('Aureus') looks spectacular against dark-foliaged plants (yew, holly).

D8. Ivy (*Hedera helix* / *H. hibernica* — native Irish ivy)

 **Reference photo:** [Ivy — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ● Full shade to ☀ full sun. One of the most light-tolerant plants. In deep shade variegated forms lose markings; green forms thrive.

Soil needs: Almost any soil including heavy clay, pH 5.0–8.0.

Soil prep: Minimal — basic compost addition to planting hole.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–50cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required. Balanced slow-release in spring if plant appears weak. Annual bark mulch. Container: balanced liquid fertiliser monthly during the growing season.

Companions: Native *H. hibernica* is one of Ireland's most important wildlife plants — nesting habitat, late nectar, winter berries. Grows beautifully under trees alongside ferns, snowdrops, and bluebells. With Virginia creeper on walls for year-round interest.

D9. Tufted Vetch (*Vicia cracca*)

 **Reference photo:** [Vicia — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant and unfussy, as a nitrogen-fixing legume.

Soil prep: Minimal — very adaptable. Improve heaviest clay with compost if desired.

Planting depth: At pot level, or sow seed directly 1–2cm deep in spring.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; scrambles via tendrils

Fertiliser: None required — like other vetches, it fixes its own nitrogen. Avoid rich feeding, which encourages excess soft growth.

Companions: Grasses, other wildflower meadow and hedgerow species; scrambles happily through shrubs or a wildlife-friendly fence/trellis via tendrils.

West of Ireland: A native climbing/scrambling wildflower with clusters of blue-purple pea flowers, valuable for bees and other pollinators. Best suited to a wildflower area, informal hedge or meadow planting rather than a formal border, as it can spread and scramble vigorously.

D10. Virginia Creeper (*Parthenocissus quinquefolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Virginia Creeper — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Autumn colour more vivid in sunnier positions.

Soil needs: Wide range including clay, pH 5.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig twice the rootball, backfill with clay/compost mix.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 1.5–3m between plants

Fertiliser: Low-maintenance. Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual bark mulch. In poor soils, slow-release granular fertiliser provides sufficient nutrition for the season.

Companions: Ivy on same wall for year-round coverage. Late-flowering clematis. Good companion for climbing roses (extends season of interest).

D11. Wisteria (*Wisteria sinensis* / *W. floribunda*)

 **Reference photo:** [Wisteria — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ✨ Full sun — south- or west-facing wall essential. Flowers very poorly in shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: 60cm wide, 40cm deep, at least 45cm from wall base. Clay/compost/grit blend over a wide area.

Planting depth: At pot level; graft union above soil. Buy grafted plants — seed-grown can take 15–20 years to flower.

Spacing: 45cm from wall; 3m between plants

Fertiliser: High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) from spring through early summer — avoid nitrogen (produces leaves, not flowers). Light dressing of bonemeal in spring. Do not feed after midsummer.

Companions: Climbing roses on adjacent wall, alliums and irises at its feet, spring bulbs at the base. Do not plant near drains or gutters.

GROUP E: BULBS

E1. Acidanthera (*Gladiolus murielae*)

 **Reference photo:** [Acidanthera — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ✨ Full sun — essential. Plant in the warmest, sunniest spot available.

Soil needs: Fertile, well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Plant on sharp sand base.

Planting depth: 10–16cm deep on a bed of sharp sand. Plant April–May. Lift after first frosts; dry and store frost-free.

Spacing: 15–20cm between corms

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser or tomato feed fortnightly from when shoots appear until flowering in August–September. Feed until foliage begins to die down.

Companions: Salvias, dahlias, gladioli, ornamental grasses, white agapanthus. Elegant near deep purple salvias or against dark evergreen hedging.

E2. Anemone (spring: *A. blanda*, *A. nemorosa*; Japanese/autumn: *A. × hybrida*)

 **Reference photo:** [Anemone — view on Wikipedia](#)

Spring anemones: Light: ☁ Partial shade (woodland conditions). *A. nemorosa* is native Irish.

Spacing: Spring Anemone: 10cm between corms. Japanese/Autumn Anemone: 45–60cm between plants; can spread. **Depth:** 5–8cm. Soak de Caen corms 24 hours before planting. **Fertiliser:** Not heavy feeders. Light balanced fertiliser in spring. Allow foliage to die back naturally. **Companions:** Snowdrops, bluebells, foxgloves in woodland-edge bed.

Japanese/Autumn anemones: **Light:** ☁ Partial shade to full sun. Excellent in semi-shaded spots. **Depth:** At pot level. **Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in spring and compost mulch. Low-maintenance. **Companions:** Hostas, astilbe, hellebores (all share moisture and partial-shade requirements). Can spread — be aware in small borders.

E3. Checkered Lily / Snake's Head Fritillary (*Fritillaria meleagris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Fritillaria meleagris \(Checkered / Snake's Head Lily\)](#) — [view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade; naturally a damp-meadow plant, so tolerates more shade and moisture than most bulbs.

Soil needs: Moist but reasonably drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Unusually for a bulb, tolerates damper clay conditions better than most, but still dislikes being permanently waterlogged.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost; heavy amendment with grit is less critical here than for most bulbs given its natural preference for damper ground.

Planting depth: 10cm deep, pointed end up. Small bulbs dry out quickly if left out of the ground — plant promptly after purchase.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Light bonemeal at planting. Otherwise little required; allow foliage to die back naturally.

Companions: Naturalised in grass with other spring bulbs such as snowdrops and daffodils; also suits damp borders near pond margins.

West of Ireland: Distinctive nodding, checkerboard-patterned purple (or white) bells in spring. One of the easier fritillarias to naturalise given the moist west of Ireland climate — good for damp meadow-style planting or the margins of a pond garden.

E4. Corn Lily (*Ixia* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Ixia](#) — [view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Light, very free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Corms rot in wet, heavy clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with grit, or grow in containers of free-draining compost for best results.

Planting depth: 8–10cm deep, pointed end up.

Spacing: 5–8cm between corms

Fertiliser: Low-nitrogen bulb/liquid feed while in leaf; avoid feeding once foliage dies back.

Companions: Freesia and other South African corms with similar sun and drainage needs.

West of Ireland: Borderline hardy (RHS H3) — in most of the west of Ireland best grown in pots that can be given a sheltered, dry position over winter, or lifted and stored like gladioli in wetter gardens. Wiry stems of star-shaped flowers in early summer.

E5. Crocus (*Crocus* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Crocus](#) — [view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun preferred for most types. *C. speciosus* 'Albus' tolerates light shade under deciduous shrubs. Spring crocuses: sunny border, lawn or pot. Autumn crocuses: as for spring types.

Soil needs: Well-drained to gritty, poor to moderately fertile, pH 6.0–7.5. On heavy clay, add a handful of horticultural grit beneath each corm to prevent waterlogging. Spring types tolerate summer moisture if drainage is right; specialist alpine types prefer dry summers and are best grown in pots.

Soil prep: Add 20–25% grit to clay planting areas. In lawns, use a bulb auger or trowel to make individual holes; place a little grit beneath each corm.

Planting depth: To naturalise *C. tommasinianus* and *C. chrysanthus* plant 7–10cm deep in small groups. In garden lawns, Dutch hybrids have bigger corms and can go deeper at 12cm. Space individually about 9cm apart. Plant with pointed tip facing upward in September–November. A 20cm pot holds 15–20 corms comfortably — layer them 5–8cm deep, almost touching, for a dense display. Use a mix of multipurpose compost and horticultural grit (roughly 3:1) for sharp drainage.

Spacing: 8–9cm between corms

Fertiliser: Feed after flowering when leaves are still in active growth. Very little feeding required otherwise. A light balanced bulb fertiliser while foliage is green is sufficient. Allow foliage to yellow before removing — this feeds the corm for the following year.

Companions: For a layered spring display in grass, combine crocus with snowdrops (January–February) and daffodils (March–April). The three together give nearly four months of colour before the grass needs cutting. Muscari, squill, and winter aconites are also superb companions. Excellent beneath deciduous shrubs. Do not mow for at least 6 weeks after flowering in lawns. ⚠ Squirrels and mice dig up freshly planted corms — cover with chicken wire for the first season.

Pot size: Use pots at least 15cm deep with drainage holes. A 20cm pot holds 15–20 corms comfortably.

West of Ireland: Crocuses naturalise magnificently in Irish gardens. *C. tommasinianus* (the 'Tommie' — early February, pale lilac) self-seeds prolifically and forms spreading carpets within a few years. Autumn-flowering types (*C. speciosus*, *C. sativus* — saffron crocus) extend interest into October–November.

E6. Crown Imperial (*Fritillaria imperialis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Fritillaria imperialis — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — warm, open position essential.

Soil needs: Deep, rich, well-drained, preferably alkaline, pH 6.5–8.0. Hates waterlogged clay.

Soil prep: Dig 40cm deep; clay/compost/grit 50/50 plus 30% grit. Grit or sharp sand at base.

Planting depth: 20–30cm deep, planted slightly on its side to prevent water collecting in the hollow crown top.

Spacing: 25cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser in early spring as shoots emerge. High-potash liquid feed once or twice before flowering. After flowering: balanced feed while foliage is still green. Nutritious bulb needs adequate feeding.

Companions: Tulips and alliums at similar time. Euphorbia, wallflowers. Reportedly deters moles (anecdotal).

West of Ireland: ⚠ Challenging on wet clay. Raised beds or pots with very gritty compost are the realistic approach.

E7. Daffodils (*Narcissus* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Daffodils — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Naturalise under deciduous trees.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Add grit at base of each planting hole.

Planting depth: 15cm (3× bulb height). Plant September–October.

Spacing: 10–15cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser after flowering while foliage still green. Allow foliage to yellow for at least 6 weeks before removing. Autumn compost mulch on naturalised drifts.

Companions: Snowdrops (succession), tulips (follow on), Pulmonaria and muscari for ground cover. Naturalise magnificently under apple trees.

E8. Dwarf Iris (*Iris reticulata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Dwarf Iris — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil essential; pH 6.0–7.5. Bulbs rot in wet, heavy clay over winter.

Soil prep: Improve clay generously with 30–40% horticultural grit; excellent drainage is the key requirement. Raised beds, troughs or pots are often more reliable than open clay ground.

Planting depth: 8–10cm deep, pointed end up.

Spacing: 5–8cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Bonemeal or bulb fertiliser at planting (autumn). Low-nitrogen liquid feed while in leaf after flowering, to build next year's bulb.

Companions: Snowdrops, crocus and dwarf daffodils for a very early, low-growing spring display; also excellent at the front of a border or in rockeries.

West of Ireland: One of the earliest bulbs to flower, often in February. Best in a very free-draining spot such as a raised bed, trough or pot given typical clay drainage; can struggle to persist in heavy wet ground.

E9. Freesia (*Freesia* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Freesia — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Light, free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Corms are tender/half-hardy and dislike cold, wet clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay with grit and compost, or grow entirely in containers of multipurpose/free-draining compost for reliability.

Planting depth: 5–8cm deep, pointed end up.

Spacing: 5–8cm between corms

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed fortnightly once in growth, until foliage yellows after flowering.

Companions: Ixia, other South African corms with similar needs; good in mixed pots with other tender bulbs.

West of Ireland: Not reliably frost-hardy (RHS H2–H3) — in most west of Ireland gardens best grown in containers that can be moved under cover, or lifted and stored dry over winter like gladioli. Fragrant, long-lasting cut flowers.

E10. Iron Cross (*Oxalis tetraphylla* ‘Iron Cross’)

 **Reference photo:** [Iron Cross — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: 5cm deep, growing point up.

Spacing: 10–15cm between tubers; lift over winter

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

Companions: Front-of-border and container planting with other low, colourful summer bulbs such as ixia or dwarf dahlias.

West of Ireland: Grown for its distinctive four-lobed leaves marked with a dark maroon “iron cross” pattern and pink summer flowers. Tuber is not reliably frost-hardy — lift and store dry over winter like a dahlia, or grow in containers that can be moved under cover.

E11. Lilies (*Lilium* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Lilies — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Most prefer heads in sun, roots shaded by low plants.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Drainage essential.

Soil prep: Compost and 20–25% grit. Place 5cm grit at base of each hole.

Planting depth: 15cm (3× bulb height) on a bed of grit.

Spacing: 15–30cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge. Tomato feed fortnightly from bud formation until flowering. Continue feeding until foliage yellows. Do not remove foliage until it dies back naturally.

Companions: Hostas, geraniums, low salvias (shade the soil around bulbs). Roses (lilies fill the midsummer gap). Alliums in the same border.

E12. Martagon Lily (*Lilium martagon*)

 **Reference photo:** [Martagon Lily — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade to sun; happier in dappled woodland-edge light than full baking sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained, humus-rich soil, tolerant of neutral to slightly alkaline conditions; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Compost and 20% grit at planting; unlike many lilies it tolerates heavier soil reasonably well once drainage is adequate.

Planting depth: 15cm deep (3× bulb height), on a bed of grit.

Spacing: 20–30cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge; otherwise undemanding once established. Do not remove foliage until it dies back naturally.

Companions: Naturalises well among shrubs, in light woodland or a shady border with hostas, ferns and hellebores — unlike many lilies, martagon lily is happy in part shade.

West of Ireland: More shade-tolerant and better suited to naturalising under trees/shrubs than most garden lilies, with distinctive nodding, “turk’s cap” recurved flowers in early-mid summer. Slow to establish — settle for two to three years before flowering well, but long-lived once happy.

E13. Native Bluebells (*Hyacinthoides non-scripta*)

 **Reference photo:** [Native Bluebells — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade preferred; ideal under deciduous trees where it flowers before the canopy closes. Tolerates full sun to full shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; slightly acid, pH 6.0–6.8. Tolerates clay reasonably well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould or compost; heavy grit amendment is not essential.

Planting depth: 8cm deep, pointed end up, in autumn.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Little required. Bonemeal at planting is sufficient; leave foliage to die back naturally each year to feed the bulb.

Companions: Ferns, hostas, primroses, wood anemones — classic native woodland-floor planting under deciduous trees and shrubs such as hawthorn, rowan or Japanese maple.

West of Ireland: Ireland's native bluebell, distinguished from the non-native Spanish bluebell by its narrower, more strongly recurved deep violet-blue flowers borne on one side of a nodding stem, its sweet scent, and creamy-white (not blue) pollen. Naturalises readily in a woodland-style planting and is excellent for pollinators. Spreads by both offsets and self-seeding, forming drifts over time, but is less aggressive and better behaved in a garden setting than Spanish bluebell.

⚠ Harmful if eaten; wear gloves when handling bulbs, as the sap can irritate skin.

E14. Ornamental Onion (*Allium* spp.)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Allium — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Bulbs rot in waterlogged clay, so drainage is essential.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 30% horticultural grit before planting; raised beds or mounded planting help on heavy soil.

Planting depth: Roughly 2–3× the bulb's own depth (typically 10–15cm for larger varieties), pointed end up.

Spacing: 10–20cm between bulbs depending on variety

Fertiliser: Bonemeal or bulb fertiliser at planting (autumn). Balanced liquid feed as foliage emerges in spring, stopped once flowering finishes.

Companions: Roses (alliums are classic rose-border companions and can help deter some pests), peonies, irises, ornamental grasses.

West of Ireland: Plant bulbs in autumn (September–November) for late spring/early summer flowers. Excellent in pots for good drainage on wet clay sites; leave foliage to die back naturally to feed next year's bulb.

E15. Ranunculus (*Ranunculus asiaticus*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Ranunculus — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Tubers rot in wet clay.

Soil prep: Compost and 20–30% grit. Plant on a bed of grit.

Planting depth: 5–8cm deep, claws pointing downward. Soak tubers 2–4 hours before planting. Plant in spring.

Spacing: 15–20cm between tubers

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid fertiliser every 2 weeks once shoots appear. Liquid tomato feed from bud formation until flowering. Container: monthly balanced liquid feed.

Companions: Pansies and violas in cool-season containers. Muscari, fritillaria, spring anemones flower simultaneously.

West of Ireland: ⚠ Treat as seasonal pot plant — lift after flowering, dry, and store frost-free.

E16. Snowdrops (*Galanthus nivalis*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Snowdrops — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ to ☀ Partial to full shade. Under deciduous trees is ideal — winter/spring light before canopy forms.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs

Soil needs: Humus-rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained, pH 5.5–7.0. Best planted “in the green.”

Planting depth (dry bulbs): 10cm deep, 8–10cm apart. **Planting depth (in the green):** At same depth as growing.

Fertiliser: Light balanced fertiliser in early spring while foliage is still green. Annual leaf mould or compost mulch. Allow foliage to

die back completely before removing.

Companions: Hellebores (classic January–March winter combination). Aconites, early narcissus, cyclamen coum in February–March. Underplant shrubs (forsythia, lilac) with snowdrops for colour before the shrubs flower.

E17. Snowflake (*Leucojum aestivum* — Summer Snowflake; *L. vernum* — Spring Snowflake)

 **Reference photo:** [Snowflake — view on Wikipedia](#)

Note on naming: Despite its common name, the Summer Snowflake, *Leucojum aestivum*, flowers in mid-spring and goes dormant during summer, not in summer itself. It features nodding, bell-shaped white flowers with green-tipped tepals, and is softly chocolate-scented.

Light: ☀ Full sun to partial shade. They prefer soil that stays cool and damp, making them ideal for borders, woodland edges, or near water.

Soil needs: Organically rich, medium moisture, well-drained soils in full sun to part shade. Adapts to clay soils. Plants need consistent moisture during the spring period of growth and bloom. pH 5.5–7.0. They are notably tolerant of wet and clay soils.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. Plants will naturalize well by bulb offsets. Bulbs are best left undisturbed once set in the ground. Mulch to retain summer moisture.

Planting depth: Plant dry bulbs 8–10cm deep in autumn in moist, humus-rich soil. Plant bulbs in autumn about 10cm deep and 8–10cm apart. Water well after planting and keep the soil evenly moist, especially during dry spells in spring. Allow the foliage to die back completely after flowering to feed the bulbs for next year's growth.

Spacing: 8–10cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Light balanced bulb fertiliser in spring while foliage is green, or annual compost top-dressing around the planting area. Low-maintenance once established.

Companions: Mixes beautifully with other spring flowering bulbs. Tolerates boggy spots and will do well on the edges of natural ponds. Spectacular in large sweeping drifts. Excellent with daffodils, snowdrops, hellebores, and moisture-loving plants. Plant at pond edges where it will naturalise freely.

Pot size: 30–40cm diameter, 25cm+ deep; multipurpose compost.

West of Ireland: This attractive bulb is ideal for naturalising in areas of grass or planting in generous clumps throughout the front of borders and rockeries. The moist Irish conditions and winter-spring wet suit it perfectly. An excellent naturalistic bulb for damp areas that can be challenging for other bulbs.

E18. Spring Sowbread (*Cyclamen coum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Spring Sowbread — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial to full shade; ideal under deciduous trees and shrubs.

Soil needs: Well-drained, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging around the tuber.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould/compost and grit.

Planting depth: Tuber just below the soil surface (2–3cm), flattest side down.

Spacing: 10–15cm between tubers

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed as leaves emerge in autumn/winter. Top-dress with leaf mould annually.

Companions: Snowdrops, winter aconite, hellebores — classic winter/early-spring woodland-floor planting.

West of Ireland: Flowers from midwinter into early spring, often alongside snowdrops, with attractively marbled leaves persisting after flowering. Once settled it self-seeds gently to form a carpet under trees and shrubs — avoid disturbing the tubers once established.

E19. Tulips (*Tulipa* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Tulips — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — essential.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Rot readily in wet clay.

Soil prep: Compost and 20% grit, plus grit at the base of each hole.

Planting depth: 20cm (3× bulb height). Plant pointy end up in November.

Spacing: 10–15cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: High-potash bulb fertiliser in early spring as shoots emerge. After flowering: balanced feed while foliage still green. If treating as annuals (recommended in wet Irish conditions), post-flowering feed matters less.

Companions: Forget-me-nots, wallflowers, daffodils, alliums, stocks. In pots, single-variety displays are most striking.

E20. Wild Tulip (*Tulipa sylvestris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Wild Tulip — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade to full sun; naturally a woodland-edge/damp-meadow species, more shade-tolerant than most garden tulips.

Soil needs: Fertile, moisture-retentive soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Unlike most tulips, tolerates damper conditions and some clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost; less critical to add heavy grit than for garden hybrid tulips.

Planting depth: 10–15cm deep, pointed end up.

Spacing: 10–15cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Light bonemeal at planting. Otherwise little required.

Companions: Naturalises well in grass or light woodland with daffodils and other naturalising bulbs.

West of Ireland: Fragrant, nodding, buttercup-yellow flowers in mid-spring, opening flat in sun. Spreads by underground stolons rather than forming offset bulbs, so can take a few seasons to settle and flower well but persists and slowly increases once happy — good for naturalising in damp grass or a shaded border, where it copes better than showier garden tulip hybrids.

E21. Yellow Star-of-Bethlehem (*Gagea lutea*)

 **Reference photo:** [Gagea — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade to sun; naturally a woodland-floor plant, flowering before the canopy closes.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, base-rich (near-neutral to slightly alkaline) soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Never allow it to dry out during the growing season.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost/leaf mould; avoid heavy grit amendment, since this species prefers more moisture-retentive ground than most bulbs.

Planting depth: 5–8cm deep, pointed end up.

Spacing: 5–8cm between bulbs

Fertiliser: Light bonemeal at planting. Otherwise little required; allow foliage to die back naturally.

Companions: Snowdrops, wood anemones and other early woodland-floor bulbs.

West of Ireland: A delicate, early-flowering native British woodland bulb; note that it is genuinely rare across Britain and Ireland and its status as a wild Irish native is uncertain — most sources describe it as a rare/scattered Great Britain species rather than confirmed native to Ireland, so plants sold for gardens are nursery-propagated stock rather than “native Irish” in origin. Grow in a shaded, undisturbed woodland-style corner.

GROUP F: ORNAMENTAL PERENNIALS

F1. Astilbe (*Astilbe* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Astilbe — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade to full sun if soil stays moist. Best in partial shade — avoids leaf scorch. Excellent beside ponds or in moisture-rich borders.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, clay-tolerant. pH 5.5–7.0.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. No heavy grit needed.

Planting depth: At pot level; crown at soil surface.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring. Generous compost or bark mulch — the most important care task. Do not let the plant dry out.

Companions: Hostas (perfect pairing), ferns, hellebores, rodgersias. Primulas in spring, astilbe in summer for successive display in the same moist bed.

F2. Auricula (*Primula auricula*)

 **Reference photo:** [Auricula — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade; protect from strong midday sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining, humus-rich soil; neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay generously with grit and compost; best in a raised bed, trough or pot given its need for sharp drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; do not bury.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season, stopping in winter.

Companions: Other alpine/trough plants such as saxifrage and sempervivum; traditionally displayed in individual pots on a shelf (“auricula theatre”).

West of Ireland: Alpine primula relative, best grown in pots or a raised trough rather than open clay, since winter wet is the main threat. Divide congested clumps every 2–3 years after flowering.

F3. Bearded Iris / Border Iris (*Iris germanica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Bearded Iris \(Border Iris\) — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential for good flowering — at least 6 hours daily.

Soil needs: Free-draining, neutral to slightly alkaline soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Rhizomes rot in wet, poorly-drained clay — this is the single biggest cause of failure.

Soil prep: Improve clay generously with 30% horticultural grit; raised beds or mounded planting strongly recommended on heavy soil.

Planting depth: Rhizome at or just proud of the soil surface, with the top exposed to sun — do not bury, unlike most other bulbs/rhizomes.

Spacing: 30–45cm between rhizomes; divide every 3–4 yrs

Fertiliser: Low-nitrogen, high-potash feed (e.g. tomato feed) in spring and again after flowering. Avoid manure or high-nitrogen feeds, which encourage rot.

Companions: Roses, peonies, alliums — classic sunny border companions with similar sun and drainage needs.

West of Ireland: Divide congested clumps every 3–4 years after flowering, discarding the older woody centre and replanting healthy young rhizomes. A raised, gritty, south-facing bed is the most reliable way to grow bearded iris well on west of Ireland clay.

F4. Blue Gentian (*Gentiana* spp., e.g. *G. acaulis*, *G. sino-ornata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Blue Gentian — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade, depending on species.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; most garden gentians prefer slightly acid conditions, pH 5.5–6.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost and grit; a raised bed or rockery suits most species well.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced or ericaceous feed in spring. Annual mulch with compost or leaf mould.

Companions: Heather, dwarf conifers, saxifrage — classic rockery/alpine-bed companions.

West of Ireland: Intensely blue, trumpet-shaped autumn or spring flowers (depending on species) make this a rockery highlight. The moist, mild west of Ireland climate suits autumn-flowering Asiatic gentians (*G. sino-ornata* type) particularly well, given reasonably acid soil.

F5. Clustered Bellflower (*Campanula glomerata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Clustered Bellflower — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay, preferring neutral to alkaline; pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses — sunny cottage-border companions.

West of Ireland: Dense clusters of violet-purple, upward-facing bell flowers on upright stems in summer. Spreads by rhizomes to form good-sized clumps — divide every 3–4 years to keep vigorous and to control spread in smaller borders.

F6. Columbine (*Aquilegia vulgaris* and hybrids)

 **Reference photo:** [Aquilegia — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of clay if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; self-seeds freely

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Foxgloves, hardy geraniums, roses — classic cottage-garden border companions; self-seeds readily among other perennials.

West of Ireland: Easy, reliable, and self-seeds freely — often needs thinning rather than encouraging once established. Distinctive spurred flowers in a wide range of colours through late spring/early summer.

F7. Coral Bells (*Heuchera* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Coral Bells — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade preferred; purple/dark-leaved varieties tolerate more sun, green/lime varieties prefer more shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil, rich in organic matter; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage — Heuchera dislikes waterlogging, especially in winter.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level — do not bury the crown, which can cause rot.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season. Light annual mulch with compost, keeping it away from the crown.

Companions: Hostas, astilbe, ferns, hellebores — classic shade/part-shade border and edging companions; excellent foliage contrast plant.

West of Ireland: Reliable, low-maintenance evergreen/semi-evergreen foliage perennial. Divide congested clumps every 3 years in spring or autumn to keep vigorous.

F8. Cutleaf Coneflower ‘Goldball’ (*Rudbeckia laciniata* ‘Goldball’)

 **Reference photo:** [Rudbeckia ‘Goldball’ — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun preferred. Will flower in light shade, but the shadier the location the less they will flower.

Soil needs: A good choice for improved clay soils — easy to grow if given full sun or partial shade and a moderately fertile soil that is moist but well-drained. pH 5.5–7.0. Moisture-retentive soil is important — dislikes prolonged dry periods in summer.

Soil prep: Add generous compost to clay (50/50). If the soil is very heavy or is not free draining, add lots of well-rotted compost to the area and dig it in well.

Planting depth: At pot level. Plant bare-root crowns with buds 2–3cm below soil.

Spacing: 60–90cm between; divide every 2–3 yrs

Fertiliser: Rudbeckia needs little or no regular applications of fertiliser in most garden soils. Mulching plants in borders with well-rotted manure or garden compost each spring should be sufficient. Certainly do not feed with nitrogen-rich fertilisers — this will only encourage leaf growth at the expense of flowers.

Special note on *R. laciniata*: *R. laciniata* has vigorous rhizomes (horizontal underground stems) that make it better suited to larger gardens. It might need lifting, dividing and reducing every two to three years to keep it in check. *R. laciniata* can reach 3m (10ft). This tall variety is inclined to flop, so pinch out the shoots in early summer to promote strong and bushy growth, or provide support.

Companions: Helenium, echinacea, late-flowering salvias, ornamental grasses, asters for a dramatic late-summer/autumn border. Excellent with purple-flowered plants (veronicastrum, verbenas bonariensis). The tall flowers of ‘Goldball’ are stunning in naturalistic or prairie-style planting schemes.

Pot size: For containers, use a liquid fertiliser such as Phostrogen or seaweed feed. Minimum 40–50cm diameter; deep container needed given eventual 2–3m height. ⚠ Better in-ground given ultimate vigour.

West of Ireland: Rudbeckia does very well in the moist, cool-summer Irish climate. Does not suffer from drought issues. Excellent for late summer colour when many plants are declining. Divide regularly to prevent uncontrolled spread.

F9. Daylilies (*Hemerocallis* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Daylilies — view source](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun to ☂ partial shade.

Soil needs: Most soils including clay, tolerant of a wide pH range 6.0–7.5. One of the easiest, most clay-tolerant border perennials.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost; grit optional, since daylilies are notably tolerant of heavy soil.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, roots spread out in the hole.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs

Fertiliser: Balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Roses, ornamental grasses, achillea (yarrow) — classic sunny border companions.

West of Ireland: Extremely tough, reliable, and genuinely clay-tolerant — one of the best “no-fuss” flowering perennials for west of Ireland gardens. Each flower lasts only a day, but a well-established clump produces a long succession of blooms through summer. Divide every 3–4 years to rejuvenate.

F10. Delphiniums (*Delphinium* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Delphiniums — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun — 6+ hours. Wind shelter equally essential.

Soil needs: Rich, fertile, well-drained, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig 40–50cm deep; generous compost and 20% grit on heavy clay.

Planting depth: At pot level; bare-root buds 2–5cm below soil.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants; stake essential

Fertiliser: Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from bud formation through flowering. After first flush: cut stems, apply balanced liquid feed to encourage second flush. Annual well-rotted manure mulch.

Companions: Roses, lupins, peonies, alliums, irises in cottage-garden combination. Staking mandatory. Slug protection critical in the wet west.

F11. Edelweiss (*Leontopodium alpinum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Edelweiss — view source](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile, alkaline soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Excellent drainage essential.

Soil prep: Improve clay heavily with 30–40% grit; best in a raised bed, trough or rockery.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less characterful growth.

Companions: Sempervivum, saxifrage, other alpine rockery plants with the same sharp-drainage needs.

West of Ireland: A true alpine, and one of the more challenging plants on wet west of Ireland clay — reliable success generally needs a raised, gritty, free-draining bed or trough rather than open ground. Silvery-white star-shaped flower bracts in summer.

F12. Elephant’s Ears (*Bergenia* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Elephant’s Ears — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ● Full shade to ☼ full sun. Leaves colour best in open, exposed positions.

Soil needs: Humus-rich, moist but well-drained. Excellent on clay.

Soil prep: Add compost. Unfussy.

Planting depth: At pot level; rhizome just at or slightly below surface.

Spacing: 30–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Low-maintenance. Balanced slow-release in spring, or just annual bark mulch. Do not overfeed.

Companions: Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops, pulmonaria, ferns. Bold evergreen foliage contrasts beautifully with delicate fern texture.

F13. Fern-leaf Peony (*Paeonia tenuifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Paeonia tenuifolia — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained, fertile soil, neutral to slightly alkaline; pH 6.5–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging, more so than common garden peonies.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost and 20–30% grit for extra drainage.

Planting depth: Crown/eyes no more than 2–3cm below soil level — as with all peonies, planting too deep prevents flowering.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in spring; light high-potash feed as buds form.

Companions: Alliums, bearded iris, catmint — classic sunny border companions with similar drainage needs.

West of Ireland: A smaller, earlier-flowering species peony with finely divided, fern-like foliage and deep red single flowers — distinct from the common garden peonies (*Paeonia* spp.) already in this guide. More particular about drainage than common peonies, so a raised or well-drained spot gives the best results on Irish clay.

F14. Foxgloves (*Digitalis purpurea* and perennial species)

 **Reference photo:** [Foxgloves — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Partial shade to full sun if soil stays moist.

Soil needs: Nutrient-rich, moist, pH 5.5–7.5. Native to Ireland.

Soil prep: Add compost. Very adaptable. Self-seeding.

Planting depth: At pot level; seeds sown on surface (need light to germinate).

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Low-maintenance — rarely needs feeding. Light balanced fertiliser in spring for vigorous second-year plants. Bark mulch to retain moisture.

Companions: Ferns, astilbe, hostas in shaded beds. With roses, alliums, and delphiniums in sunnier borders. Superb companion as they attract bumblebees very effectively.

F15. Globeflower (*Trollius europaeus* / *T. x cultorum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Trollius — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist to wet, humus-rich soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Unusually for a border perennial, thrives in damp ground and tolerates heavy clay very well.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost; no need for extra drainage — this plant prefers consistently moist soil.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch, keeping the crown moist.

Companions: Astilbe, hosta, candelabra primulas — classic damp border or pond-margin companions.

West of Ireland: One of the few showy border perennials genuinely suited to the wetter parts of a west of Ireland garden — round, globe-like yellow or orange flowers on upright stems in late spring. Excellent for a damp border or the margin of a pond garden.

F16. Hellebore (*Helleborus* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Hellebore — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ to ● Partial to full shade. Ideal under deciduous trees or shrubs. Avoid full sun which scorches leaves.

Soil needs: Humus-rich, fertile, moisture-retentive, pH 6.0–8.0. Excellent on clay.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. Annual compost or leaf mould mulch.

Planting depth: At pot level; crown just at or slightly below soil surface.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release in early spring after clearing old foliage. Annual compost mulch after flowering — most effective treatment. Takes 2–3 years to settle after planting; do not disturb once established.

Companions: Snowdrops (January–March together — one of the great winter garden combinations). Cyclamen coum, pulmonaria, early daffodils. Hostas and ferns alongside in summer.

F17. Hosta (*Hosta* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Hosta — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ to ● Partial to full shade. Golden types tolerate more sun; blue-leaved varieties need more shade. Avoid full sun which scorches leaves.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, fertile. Grows well on clay.

Soil prep: Add generous compost.

Planting depth: At pot level; crown just at soil surface.

Spacing: 30–90cm (variety-dependent)

Fertiliser: Balanced slow-release granular in spring. Balanced liquid feed monthly April through midsummer. Do not feed after August. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia. Snowdrops and winter aconites bloom in the gaps before hostas emerge in spring. ⚠ Slugs and snails are the main challenge in the moist west — wool pellets, copper tape (on pots), or nematode treatments are essential companions.

F18. Lady's Bedstraw (*Galium verum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lady's Bedstraw — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry conditions; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — this native wildflower thrives on lean soil; excess compost/fertility encourages weak, floppy growth.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required — over-feeding is counterproductive for this meadow wildflower.

Companions: Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wild grasses — classic dry meadow/wildflower planting.

West of Ireland: A native wildflower with masses of tiny, honey-scented yellow flowers in summer, traditionally used to stuff mattresses (hence the name) and once used to curdle milk in cheesemaking. Best suited to a wildflower meadow area or dry, sunny bank rather than a fertile border.

F19. Lilyleaf Ladybells (*Adenophora liliifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lilyleaf Ladybells — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; resents root disturbance once established (like many bellflower relatives, it has a fleshy taproot), so choose the final position with care.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Other cottage-border perennials such as clustered bellflower, delphiniums, phlox.

West of Ireland: A relative of the campanulas, with nodding, pale blue-violet bell flowers on upright stems in summer. Less commonly available than campanulas but similarly easy once settled — best left undisturbed once planted.

F20. Lungworts (*Pulmonaria* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Lungworts — view source](#)

Light: ☂ Partial to full shade.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Hellebores, ferns, hostas — classic early-spring woodland/shade border planting; one of the earliest nectar sources for bees.

West of Ireland: Reliable, easy, semi-evergreen shade perennial with attractively spotted leaves and pink-to-blue spring flowers (often both colours on the same plant). Spreads gently to form good groundcover under trees and shrubs; divide every 3–4 years.

F21. Lupins (*Lupinus polyphyllus* and hybrids)

 **Reference photo:** [Lupins — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☂ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, slightly acid soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes shallow chalk.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost; avoid excess lime.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; resents root disturbance, so choose the final position with care.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring — like other legumes, lupins fix some of their own nitrogen, so avoid overfeeding.

Companions: Delphiniums, roses, foxgloves — classic tall cottage-border companions.

West of Ireland: Tall, showy flower spikes in early-mid summer in a wide colour range. Slug damage to young shoots is the main challenge on damp Irish clay — protect emerging growth in spring. Cut back after flowering to encourage a possible second, smaller flush.

F22. Monkshood (*Aconitum napellus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Aconitum / Monkshood — view source](#)

Light: ☂ Partial shade to full sun; prefers cooler root conditions.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, wear gloves

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Delphiniums, hostas, astilbe — classic cottage/damp border companions.

West of Ireland: Reliable, long-lived tall spikes of deep blue-purple hooded flowers in late summer.

⚠ **All parts are highly toxic if ingested, and sap can irritate skin on contact — wear gloves when handling, and site away from children's play areas and vegetable beds.**

F23. Pasqueflower (*Pulsatilla vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Pasqueflower — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — essential. Hates shade.

Soil needs: Excellent drainage, pH 6.5–8.0. Hates wet clay. Raised bed or pot essential.

Soil prep: 40–50% grit/compost mix in raised bed or container.

Planting depth: At pot level. Do not disturb once established.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Virtually no feeding needed. Adapted to lean limestone soils. Nitrogen causes floppy, non-flowering growth. Grit mulch on the surface is more beneficial than any fertiliser.

Companions: Eryngium, Dianthus, Scabiosa, Achillea, ornamental grasses in a gravel garden. Thyme and other rock garden plants nearby.

F24. Peonies (*Paeonia* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Peonies — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ to ☁ Full sun to partial shade. At least 4–6 hours for good flowering.

Spacing: 90cm between plants

Soil needs: Free-draining, fertile, pH 6.5–7.0.

Planting depth (herbaceous): ⚠ Eyes MAX 2.5–5cm below soil. Too deep = no flowers. The most commonly made planting mistake.

Planting depth (tree peony): Graft union 10–15cm below surface.

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser in early spring as red shoots emerge. High-potash feed (tomato feed) as buds develop. Annual well-rotted compost mulch, keeping mulch away from crown.

Companions: Alliums (flower as peonies fade — elegant combination). Salvia, irises, delphiniums in mixed border. Roses, foxgloves, geraniums. Avoid planting near taller shade-casting plants.

F25. Perennial Flax (*Linum perenne*)

 **Reference photo:** [Linum / Perennial Flax — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry conditions; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes winter wet.

Soil prep: Improve clay with grit for drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring; avoid rich soil, which shortens the plant's lifespan.

Companions: Achillea (yarrow), lavender, other sun-loving, drought-tolerant border perennials.

West of Ireland: Delicate, sky-blue flowers open fresh each morning through summer on airy, wiry stems. Can be short-lived, especially where drainage is poor — a raised or gritty spot extends its life considerably on Irish clay.

F26. Pheasant's Eye (*Adonis vernalis* / *A. amurensis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Adonis — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade (some afternoon shade in summer, when the plant is dormant, is fine).

Soil needs: Well-drained, humus-rich soil; neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit for good drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; ⚠ toxic

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

Companions: Snowdrops, hellebores and other very early spring flowers; goes dormant by summer, so pair with later perennials to fill the gap.

West of Ireland: One of the earliest perennials to flower, with bright yellow, buttercup-like blooms often appearing in late winter. Slow to establish and resents disturbance, so choose its position carefully and leave undisturbed once planted.

⚠ All parts are toxic if ingested.

F27. Pinks (*Dianthus plumarius* and garden hybrids)

 **Reference photo:** [Pinks — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — at least 6 hours. Dianthus should be planted in full sun but can tolerate some shade.

Soil needs: Dianthus grows best in rich, neutral soil on the alkaline side, best pH range 5.8 to 6.2. While the plants perform well in

rich soil, most dianthus are able to adapt to a wide range of soil conditions, including those with high amounts of clay or sand. Well-drained soil and good air circulation are necessary to avoid root rot and fungal diseases.

Soil prep: Add compost and 20–25% grit to clay. Good drainage is essential — dianthus rots in waterlogged clay.

Planting depth: At pot level; plant at the same depth as in the nursery pot. Space 25–35cm apart.

Spacing: 25–35cm between plants

Fertiliser: Routine applications of fertilizer are not required. However, they may enjoy annual applications of a well-balanced feed in early spring, which will promote new growth and enhance flowering. Perennial species can be fed once in late spring with an organic fertiliser such as comfrey or chicken pellets. Dianthus plants in containers will need feeding fortnightly with a liquid feed.

Companions: Good garden companions for Dianthus include Campanula, Iberis sempervirens, Iris, Phlox subulata, Stachys lanata. Also rosemary, lavender, thyme, and alliums in a well-drained sunny border. Classic cottage garden plant that combines with roses, stocks, and sweet William.

Pot size: Aim for a pot that's at least 12 to 15 inches (30–38cm) deep. 25–35cm diameter; multipurpose compost with 20% grit.

West of Ireland: Dianthus can thrive in the west of Ireland in well-drained positions. The moist winters are the main challenge — a raised bed with gritty soil or a sheltered, south-facing spot gives the best results. Modern perennial pinks (e.g. 'Doris', 'Mrs Sinkins', Devon series) are more reliable than old cottage varieties.

F28. Siberian Statice (*Goniolimon tataricum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Siberian Statice — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes winter wet.

Soil prep: Improve clay with grit for good drainage.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; deep taproot, so choose the final position with care.

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring; avoid rich soil.

Companions: Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum — classic gravel-garden or dried-flower border companions.

West of Ireland: Airy sprays of small white/papery flowers held well above a basal rosette, popular for drying. Best given a raised, gritty, well-drained spot given the west of Ireland's high rainfall, as it is more prone to winter losses on flat wet clay than many border perennials.

F29. Spreading Bellflower (*Campanula patula*)

 **Reference photo:** [Spreading Bellflower — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, or sow seed on the surface in late spring/summer.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; biennial/short-lived

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring.

Companions: Ox-eye daisy, wild grasses, other cottage/meadow-style border companions.

West of Ireland: A biennial or short-lived perennial native British/Irish wildflower with open, star-shaped violet-blue bells on branching stems in summer — different from the more vigorously spreading (and often invasive in gardens) *Campanula rapunculoides*. Self-seeds gently; deadhead if self-seeding is not wanted.

F30. Stocks (*Matthiola incana* / *M. longipetala*)

 **Reference photo:** [Stocks — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Best fragrance in the evening in a sheltered spot.

Soil needs: Well-drained, pH 6.5–7.5. Slightly alkaline preferred.

Soil prep: Compost and 20% grit.

Planting depth: At pot level; seeds surface-sown.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Balanced fertiliser at planting. Liquid tomato feed fortnightly once buds appear. Moderate feeder — do not overfeed with nitrogen.

Companions: Wallflowers, sweet William, pansies. Place near seating areas or windows for exceptional evening fragrance.

F31. Sweet William (*Dianthus barbatus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Sweet William — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Carnations, sweet William and cottage pinks do best in rich, well-draining soil that's kept moist but not soggy.

Soil needs: Sweet William does best in rich, well-draining soil that's kept moist but not soggy. pH 5.8–6.5. Slightly alkaline preferred. Tolerates clay if drainage improved.

Soil prep: Add compost and 20% grit to clay. Good drainage needed.

Planting depth: At pot level. Sow seed in spring or summer (biennial variety: sow June–July to flower next year). Space 30cm apart.

Spacing: 30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Sweet Williams and pinks are most long-lived and floriferous when planted in well-drained, neutral to slightly alkaline soil. Avoid overwatering as they don't like to be soggy or waterlogged. A balanced fertiliser at planting; liquid feed fortnightly in containers while in flower.

Companions: Pinks, stocks, foxgloves, forget-me-nots, wallflowers, pansies, roses. Excellent cut flower — place near the cutting garden. Use *D. barbatus* mass-planted in formal gardens; scatter them about the cottage garden to allow them to self-sow.

Pot size: 25–30cm diameter; multipurpose compost with 20% grit.

West of Ireland: Sweet William can be kept for another year — most successful on free-draining soil in mild winters. The mild winters of the west of Ireland are an advantage. Treat as biennial for best results — sow fresh seeds each year in summer for the following year's display.

F32. Toadflax (*Linaria vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Toadflax — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Minimal — this native wildflower is unfussy; avoid over-rich soil, which encourages excess soft growth and spread.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, or sow seed on the surface.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; spreads readily

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, other native wildflower meadow companions.

West of Ireland: A native wildflower with snapdragon-like yellow and orange flowers on upright spikes through summer, valuable for bees. Spreads by rhizomes and self-seeds readily, so best suited to a wildflower area or informal bank rather than a tidy border, where it can be to be kept in check.

F33. Vervain (*Verbena officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Vervain — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor, dry conditions once established.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required; avoid rich soil, which produces floppy growth.

Companions: Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses — classic gravel-garden and pollinator-border companions.

West of Ireland: A native wildflower with wiry, airy stems of tiny lilac flowers through summer, valuable for pollinators, and long used in traditional herbal medicine. Self-seeds gently; best in a sunny, well-drained spot rather than heavy wet clay.

F34. Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*)

 **Reference photo:** [Yarrow — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun — at least 6–8 hours. Tolerates partial shade but flowers less freely and becomes leggy.

Soil needs: Loamy soil is ideal, but yarrow tolerates clay soil if it drains well. Loosen soil 12–15 inches deep and mix in 2–4 inches of compost before planting. Avoid overly rich soil; too much fertility can cause floppy stems. pH 5.5–7.0. Very adaptable — will grow in poor soil.

Soil prep: Loosen soil to 30–40cm depth and mix in compost before planting. Do not add heavy nitrogen; this causes floppy stems. On clay, add 15–20% grit to improve drainage.

Planting depth: At pot level; bare-root crowns with buds 2–3cm below soil surface. Space 30–60cm apart.

Spacing: 30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs

Fertiliser: Apply a thin layer of compost each spring. Additional fertiliser is rarely necessary. Over-feeding produces tall, floppy plants that fall over. Yarrow needs little or no regular applications of fertiliser in most garden soils. Mulching plants in borders with well-rotted manure or garden compost each spring should be sufficient.

Companions: Yarrow helps deter unwanted pests, attracts native insects and predators like those that manage aphids and caterpillars, and works quietly to improve soil quality by replenishing nutrients. Yarrow pairs beautifully with weigela and hydrangea. Also excellent with roses, delphiniums, salvias, ornamental grasses, and echinacea. One of the best pollinator plants — flat-topped flowers are perfect landing platforms for hoverflies, butterflies and bees. ⚠ Can spread aggressively in good garden soil — divide every 2–3 years.

Pot size: 30cm diameter, 25cm deep container; multipurpose compost with 20% grit.

West of Ireland: Native *A. millefolium* grows wild throughout Ireland and is extremely well adapted to Irish conditions. Tolerates the wet, windy west coast. Excellent for naturalistic planting, wildflower meadow schemes, and cottage gardens.

GROUP G: ANNUAL FLOWERS

G1. Chinese Pink (*Dianthus chinensis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Chinese Pink — view source](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun.

Soil needs: Free-draining soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Dislikes waterlogged clay.

Soil prep: Improve clay with 30% grit; raised bed or container recommended.

Planting depth: At pot level, or sow seed 3mm deep in spring.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; grow as annual/biennial

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

Companions: Other annual bedding such as cornflower and love-in-a-mist for a cottage-style summer border.

West of Ireland: Usually grown as an annual or short-lived biennial bedding plant rather than a long-term perennial (unlike the perennial pinks, *Dianthus plumarius*, already in this guide) — sow or plant fresh each year for the most reliable colourful summer display. Excellent drainage is essential given typical clay conditions.

G2. Cornflower (*Centaurea cyanus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Cornflower — view source](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit; avoid over-rich ground, which produces weak, floppy stems.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1–2cm deep, spring (or autumn for earlier flowers).

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

Fertiliser: Little required.

Companions: Poppies, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima — classic hardy-annual cutting garden mix, and good for pollinators.

West of Ireland: Easy, reliable, and long-flowering through summer if deadheaded regularly. Self-seeds freely; the classic bright blue form is most traditional, though pink and white forms are also available.

G3. Greater Quaking Grass (*Briza maxima*)

 **Reference photo:** [Briza Maxima — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: Sow seed 5mm deep in spring, direct or in trays.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

Fertiliser: Little required; over-feeding produces floppy growth.

Companions: Cornflower, poppies, love-in-a-mist — classic annual cutting-garden/cottage border mix; the papery seed heads are excellent for dried arrangements.

West of Ireland: An easy hardy annual ornamental grass with distinctive nodding, oat-like seed heads that rustle in the breeze — self-seeds readily, so allow some heads to drop if you want it to return next year, or deadhead if not.

G4. Lacy Phacelia (*Phacelia tanacetifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Phacelia — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Very unfussy.

Soil prep: Minimal — often used as a green manure/cover crop precisely because it grows so easily on poor or heavy ground.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, spring through summer for successional flowering.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; annual, sow successional

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Excellent sown alongside or near vegetable beds and fruit — one of the very best plants for attracting bees and other pollinators, and can be dug in as a green manure to improve soil structure.

West of Ireland: Fast, easy, and highly valuable for pollinators, with fuzzy purple-blue flower heads. Sow a patch near the vegetable garden or fruit trees to boost pollination, or use as a soil-improving green manure between crops.

G5. Love-in-a-Mist (*Nigella damascena*)

 **Reference photo:** [Love-in-a-Mist — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, spring or autumn, direct where it is to flower (dislikes root disturbance from transplanting).

Spacing: 20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed if soil is poor; otherwise little required.

Companions: Cornflower, poppies, briza maxima — classic hardy annual cutting garden mix; the inflated seed pods are attractive dried.

West of Ireland: Airy, feathery foliage surrounds delicate blue, white or pink flowers in summer, followed by ornamental seed pods. Self-seeds very readily — thin seedlings if too dense, or deadhead before seed pods form if self-seeding isn't wanted.

G6. Poppies (*Papaver* spp., e.g. *P. rhoeas*, Shirley poppies)

 **Reference photo:** [Poppies — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit; avoid over-rich ground.

Planting depth: Sow seed on the surface or just barely covered (needs light to germinate), spring or autumn, direct where it is to flower.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely

Fertiliser: Little required.

Companions: Cornflower, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima — classic hardy annual meadow/cutting garden mix.

West of Ireland: The classic annual field/Shirley poppy self-seeds very freely and is one of the easiest hardy annuals to naturalise in a sunny border or wildflower patch. (Note: perennial Oriental poppies, *Papaver orientale*, are a different, longer-lived border plant with similar sun/drainage needs if a non-annual poppy is wanted instead.)

G7. Sweet Peas (*Lathyrus odoratus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Sweet Peas — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Dig in plenty of compost — sweet peas are hungrier and thirstier than most annuals. Improve drainage with grit if the site is very wet.

Planting depth: Sow seed 2cm deep, spring (or autumn under cover for earlier, stronger plants).

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants against support

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed weekly once flowering begins; a high-potash feed (tomato feed) encourages more blooms.

Companions: Climbing roses, clematis — grow up the same wall/trellis for a long season of colour; also a classic vegetable-garden companion, attracting pollinators.

West of Ireland: Fragrant, prolific climbing annual for a sunny wall, trellis or wigwam of canes — regular picking (rather than letting pods form) is the key to a long flowering season. Needs support to climb by tendrils and consistent moisture at the roots.

GROUP H: KITCHEN HERBS & VEGETABLES

H1. Catnip (*Nepeta cataria*)

 **Reference photo:** [Catnip — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required; over-feeding produces floppy, less aromatic growth.

Companions: Brassicas (said to deter flea beetle and cabbage moth), roses (said to deter aphids); popular with cats, which can damage young plants by rolling on them.

West of Ireland: Easy and reliable, though may need protection from cats when young (a cloche or wire cage over new plants prevents damage until established). Trim after flowering to keep compact and encourage fresh growth.

H2. Coriander (*Coriandrum sativum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Coriander — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☁ Full sun to partial shade. Shade reduces bolting — useful in the cool west of Ireland.

Soil needs: Light, well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Annual. Do NOT transplant — sow direct.

Planting depth: Sow direct 5mm deep. Thin to 15–20cm.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Minimal. Light balanced liquid feed once or twice during growing season. Do not overfeed — promotes fast, leafy bolting growth.

Companions: Parsley, brassicas (nearby). Do NOT grow adjacent to fennel or dill (cross-pollination ruins flavour of both if they flower together). Attracts beneficial insects.

H3. Cucumbers (*Cucumis sativus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Cucumbers — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun, sheltered from wind.

Soil needs: Rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Dig in plenty of well-rotted compost/manure. Raise beds or mound slightly on heavy clay for better drainage and warmth.

Planting depth: At pot level, after all risk of frost has passed (outdoor “ridge” types) or under cover for greenhouse types.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) weekly once fruits begin to set.

Companions: Nasturtiums (trap crop for aphids), dill, sweetcorn as a windbreak.

West of Ireland: Outdoor “ridge” cucumbers cope reasonably with the cooler west of Ireland summer, though a sheltered, sunny spot or polytunnel/greenhouse gives more reliable results and a longer season than fully exposed outdoor growing.

H4. Dill (*Anethum graveolens*)

 **Reference photo:** [Dill — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun. Sheltered from wind (tall and floppy).

Soil needs: Moist, medium-to-well-drained, pH 5.5–7.0. Annual. Sow direct.

Planting depth: Sow direct, cover 3–5mm. Thin to 20–30cm.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Minimal. Light balanced fertiliser once during the season. Overfeeding promotes rapid bolting.

Companions: Brassicas, lettuce, cucumbers. Do NOT plant near fennel or coriander (cross-pollination). Attracts hoverflies and beneficial insects.

H5. Green Onions (*Allium fistulosum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Green Onions / Scallions — view source](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun to ☂ partial shade.

Soil needs: Fertile, well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost; light and free-draining is best.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, or plant sets at pot level, spring through summer for successional harvests.

Spacing: 5–8cm between plants; sow successionally

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

Companions: Carrots (mutually deters carrot fly and onion fly), rocket, radish — classic salad-bed companions.

West of Ireland: Fast, easy, and can be sown successionally every few weeks from spring to late summer for a continuous harvest of mild, slender salad onions.

H6. Lavender (*Lavandula angustifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lavender — view source](#)

Light: ☼ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily.

Soil needs: Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile, neutral to alkaline soil; pH 6.5–8.0. Excellent drainage is essential — dislikes sitting in wet clay, especially over winter.

Soil prep: Mix clay generously with 30%+ horticultural grit, or plant on a raised mound/bed. A layer of grit or pebbles as surface mulch keeps the crown dry.

Planting depth: At pot level; do not bury the woody base.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less aromatic growth prone to winter damage.

Companions: Roses (classic underplanting), rosemary, thyme and other Mediterranean herbs with the same sun/drainage needs.

West of Ireland: Along with rosemary, one of the herbs most likely to struggle on wet west of Ireland clay in winter — a raised bed, gritty mound, or large terracotta container in a sheltered, sunny spot gives much better results than open ground. Trim lightly after flowering; avoid cutting into old bare wood.

H7. Lemon Balm (*Melissa officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Melissa / Lemon Balm — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5.

Soil prep: Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants; spreads readily

Fertiliser: Little required; over-feeding produces excess soft growth.

Companions: Brassicas, tomatoes; attractive to bees when in flower.

West of Ireland: Easy, vigorous, and self-seeds/spreads readily — best in a container or a bed where its spread can be controlled, similar to mint. Fresh lemon-scented leaves are excellent for tea.

H8. Mint (*Mentha* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Mint — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. More aromatic in sun; more leaves in shade.

Soil needs: Moist, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. ⚠ **Always grow in a container or with a deep root barrier — invasive spreader.**

Planting depth: At pot level. Root barrier in ground should be 30cm deep. Container minimum 30cm diameter and depth.

Spacing: 60cm if in ground with root barrier

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed monthly during the growing season. Cut back after flowering and feed to encourage fresh growth. Repot yearly into fresh compost.

Companions: Use pots of mint near brassicas, tomatoes, and beans as a pest deterrent (volatile oils without the invasive roots). Peppermint near roses reportedly deters aphids.

H9. Mother of Thyme / Creeping Thyme (*Thymus serpyllum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Mother of Thyme / Creeping Thyme — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — essential. Requires maximum sunshine and warmth.

Soil needs: Well-drained to dry, poor soil, pH 6.0–8.0. Dislikes wet clay. Raised bed or pot essential.

Soil prep: 40–50% grit with compost. Small pebbles as surface mulch.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very low nutrient requirements — evolved on lean soil. A very light dressing of balanced fertiliser in spring is the maximum needed. Do not feed in summer or autumn. Grit mulch more beneficial than fertiliser.

Companions: Rosemary, oregano, lavender, creeping juniper. Grows beautifully between paving stones or on dry walls. Alongside pasqueflower in a raised sunny bed.

H10. Nasturtiums (*Tropaeolum majus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Nasturtiums — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Poor to moderately fertile, well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Rich soil produces excess leaves at the expense of flowers.

Soil prep: Minimal — nasturtiums thrive on poor soil; avoid heavy feeding or over-improving the ground.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1–2cm deep, direct after frost risk has passed.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

Fertiliser: None to very little required.

Companions: Already used throughout this guide as a companion plant for apples, brassicas and cucumbers — nasturtiums act as a “trap crop” drawing aphids and cabbage white butterflies away from vegetables, and the peppery leaves and flowers are edible in salads.

West of Ireland: One of the easiest, most useful companion flowers for the vegetable garden — self-seeds readily and tolerates

poor, dry corners well, though it can be checked by heavy Atlantic rain in a very wet summer.

H11. Oregano / Wild Marjoram (*Origanum vulgare*)

 **Reference photo:** [Oregano / Wild Marjoram — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun — open, sunny position for best aroma and flavour.

Soil needs: Well-drained, slightly alkaline preferred, pH 6.5–8.0.

Soil prep: 30–40% grit to clay/compost mix. Raised beds ideal.

Planting depth: At pot level.

Spacing: 30–45cm between plants

Fertiliser: Low nutrient requirements. Light balanced fertiliser in spring only. Avoid nitrogen-heavy feeds (reduces aromatic oil content). Container: monthly balanced liquid at half-strength during growing season.

Companions: Thyme, rosemary, sage. Oregano flowers attract pollinators very effectively — excellent companion for fruit trees, raspberries, and other fruiting plants.

H12. Radish (*Raphanus sativus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Radish — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Light, fertile, well-drained soil, free of stones; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost and grit for a looser, freer-draining bed — stony or heavy clay produces misshapen roots.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, direct, from spring through late summer for successional harvests.

Spacing: 2–3cm between plants; sow successionally

Fertiliser: Little required; rich soil produces excess leaf at the expense of the root.

Companions: Carrots, lettuce, green onions — classic salad-bed companions; also used as a fast “marker crop” sown alongside slower vegetables.

West of Ireland: One of the fastest vegetables to harvest (as little as 3–4 weeks), making it ideal for succession sowing every couple of weeks through the growing season.

H13. Rocket (*Eruca sativa*)

 **Reference photo:** [Rocket — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade (some shade helps prevent premature bolting in summer heat).

Soil needs: Fertile, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost.

Planting depth: Sow seed 1cm deep, direct, spring through autumn for successional harvests.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; sow successionally

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed occasionally through the growing season.

Companions: Radish, green onions, lettuce — classic salad-bed companions.

West of Ireland: Fast-growing and easy; keep well watered and pick young leaves regularly to delay bolting (running to flower), which happens quickly in dry or hot spells. Sow successionally every few weeks for a continuous supply.

H14. Rosemary (*Salvia rosmarinus*, syn. *Rosmarinus officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Rosemary — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily. Poor, leggy growth and reduced flavour in shade.

Soil needs: Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Excellent drainage is essential — rosemary is Mediterranean in origin and will not tolerate sitting in wet clay, especially over winter.

Soil prep: Mix clay generously with 30%+ horticultural grit, or plant on a raised mound/bed. Add a layer of grit or pebbles as surface mulch to keep the crown dry.

Planting depth: At pot level; do not bury the woody base.

Spacing: 45–60cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less aromatic growth. A light balanced feed in spring is sufficient. Container plants: occasional liquid feed through summer.

Companions: Classic companion for brassicas (deters cabbage moth), carrots and beans in the vegetable garden; also thyme, lavender and other Mediterranean herbs with the same sun/drainage needs.

West of Ireland: One of the herbs most likely to struggle on wet west of Ireland clay in winter — a raised bed, gritty mound, or a large terracotta container that can be given a sheltered spot is strongly recommended over open ground. Trim lightly after flowering to keep compact; avoid cutting into old bare wood.

H15. Scurvy Grass (*Cochlearia officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Scurvy Grass — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained soil, tolerant of salty/coastal conditions; pH 6.5–7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with compost; naturally grows in fairly poor, gritty or rocky coastal ground, so avoid over-rich soil.

Planting depth: At pot level, or sow seed on the surface.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required.

Companions: Sea kale, other coastal/salt-tolerant edible plants if grown in a coastal garden setting.

West of Ireland: A native coastal plant of saltmarshes, cliffs and rocky shores right around the Irish coast, historically eaten by sailors for its high vitamin C content (hence the name). Leaves have a strong, peppery, mustard-like flavour, best used sparingly in salads; happiest in a sunny spot that isn't far removed from its natural coastal, slightly salty preference.

H16. Zucchini / Courgette (*Cucurbita pepo*)

 **Reference photo:** [Zucchini / Courgette — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun, sheltered from wind.

Soil needs: Rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Dig in plenty of well-rotted compost/manure into a planting hole or mound — courgettes are hungry, thirsty plants.

Planting depth: At pot level, after all risk of frost has passed.

Spacing: 60–90cm between plants

Fertiliser: High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) weekly once flowering/fruiting begins.

Companions: Nasturtiums (trap crop), sweetcorn, beans — classic “three sisters”-adjacent vegetable bed companions.

West of Ireland: Very productive in a warm, sheltered, sunny spot; keep well watered in dry spells and harvest fruit young and regularly (every 2–3 days once cropping) to keep plants producing through the season.

GROUP I: SHADE & WOODLAND PLANTS

I1. Common Dog Violet (*Viola riviniana*)

 **Reference photo:** [Common Dog Violet — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial shade; tolerates full sun to full shade.

Soil needs: Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.0.

Soil prep: Minimal — very adaptable native woodland-floor plant.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Primroses, wood sorrel, ferns — classic native woodland-floor groundcover; the larval food plant for several fritillary butterflies.

West of Ireland: Easy, unfussy native wildflower with violet-blue flowers in spring, valuable groundcover under trees and shrubs, and important for wildlife. Self-seeds gently to form drifts.

12. Irish Native Mosses

 **Reference photo:** [Irish Native Mosses — view source](#)

Light: ☂ Partial to full shade; most native mosses scorch in strong, direct sun.

Spacing: Establish as low patches; allow to spread and knit together naturally over 1-2 growing seasons.

Soil/surface needs: Consistently moist, humid conditions on soil, rock, tree bases, walls or fallen wood; most prefer slightly acid, humus-rich conditions, though some (like common tamarisk-moss) tolerate neutral ground.

Establishing mosses: Unlike flowering plants, mosses are not “planted” in the usual sense — they establish from spores or small transplanted clumps (“moss transplant”) pressed onto a clean, consistently damp surface (soil, rock, log, or the shaded base of a wall) and kept moist while they knit in, generally over one growing season.

Care: No feeding — added fertiliser harms moss. Keep the area free of fallen leaf litter, which can smother it, and maintain humidity/shade; mosses generally do not need protection from cold.

Companions: Ferns, wood sorrel, primroses and other shaded, damp woodland-floor plants; mosses are a natural companion groundcover beneath the native ferns already in this guide.

West of Ireland: Ireland’s mild, exceptionally damp Atlantic climate is superb for mosses generally, and the west of Ireland (especially Kerry’s oceanic woodlands) is internationally important for its bryophyte (moss and liverwort) diversity. A shaded, damp corner, old wall, or fallen log left undisturbed will often colonise naturally with little help. A selection of common native species suited to garden conditions:

Common name	Species	Typical habitat
Fox-tail Feather-moss	<i>Thamnobryum alopecurum</i>	Shaded rocks, streamsides, tree bases in humid woodland
Common Tamarisk-moss	<i>Thuidium tamariscinum</i>	Damp ground and rotting logs in woodland; tolerates neutral soils
Bank Haircap Moss	<i>Polytrichastrum formosum</i>	Shaded banks, ditches, woodland and tree stumps on acidic soils
Common Haircap	<i>Polytrichum commune</i>	Damp, acidic ground, bog margins and woodland
Swan’s-neck Thyme-moss	<i>Mnium hornum</i>	Very common on tree bases, rotting wood and acidic woodland floor
Springy Turf-moss	<i>Rhytidiadelphus squarrosus</i>	Damp lawns, banks and open woodland; tolerant of some sun

13. Lily of the Valley (*Convallaria majalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Convallaria — view source](#)

Light: ☂ Partial to full shade.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost/leaf mould.

Planting depth: Rhizome (“pip”) 2–3cm deep, growing point up, in autumn.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, spreads

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould mulch.

Companions: Ferns, hostas, hellebores — classic shaded woodland-floor groundcover.

West of Ireland: Fragrant white bell flowers in late spring, spreading by rhizomes to form good groundcover under trees and shrubs over time — can be vigorous once established, so give it room or a contained bed if a tidy border is wanted.

⚠ All parts are toxic if ingested.

14. Native Irish Ferns

Reference photos: [Male Fern](#) · [Lady Fern](#) · [Broad Buckler Fern](#) · [Hard Shield Fern](#) · [Polypody](#) · [Royal Fern](#) · [Deer Fern](#)

Fern	Latin Name	Light	Height	Notes
Male Fern	<i>Dryopteris filix-mas</i>	☂–●	60–100cm	Most robust native; tolerates exposed positions
Lady Fern	<i>Athyrium filix-femina</i>	☂	60–120cm	Prefers sheltered, moist shade
Broad Buckler Fern	<i>Dryopteris dilatata</i>	☂–●	60–100cm	Glossy dark fronds; excellent in deep shade
Hard Shield Fern	<i>Polystichum aculeatum</i>	☂	45–60cm	Evergreen; tolerates dry shade & coastal exposure
Polypody	<i>Polypodium vulgare</i>	☂	15–40cm	Grows on walls and banks; evergreen

Royal Fern	<i>Osmunda regalis</i>	*-☂	1-2m	Loves wet clay and boggy spots; spectacular
Deer Fern	<i>Blechnum spicant</i>	☂-●	30-60cm	Evergreen; needs acidic soil (pH 4.5-6.0)

Soil needs: Most: moist, humus-rich, acidic to neutral (pH 5.0-7.0). Deer fern: acidic conditions.

Soil prep: Add generous compost. Extra moisture retention for Royal Fern and Lady Fern.

Planting depth: At pot level. Crowns of Dryopteris and Osmunda should sit 7-12cm above soil.

Spacing: 30cm-1.5m between plants depending on species — see the smaller reference table above for details on the most garden-common ferns (Male, Royal and Deer Fern).

Fertiliser: Very low feeding requirements. Light balanced fertiliser in spring or annual compost top-dressing is sufficient. Do not overfeed. Bark mulch around base to retain moisture.

Companions: Hostas, astilbe, hellebores, snowdrops, bluebells. Native ferns under deciduous trees is the ideal naturalistic Irish planting. Japanese maple and bamboo make beautiful structural companions. Foxgloves self-seed among ferns magnificently.

West of Ireland: You are in prime fern territory. Royal Fern (*Osmunda regalis*) is spectacular in boggy west of Ireland conditions.

15. Primroses (*Primula vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Primroses — view source](#)

Light: ☂ Partial shade; tolerates more sun in the cooler, moister west of Ireland climate than in drier regions.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 5.5-7.0. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

Soil prep: Mix clay with compost/leaf mould.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 20-25cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould/compost mulch.

Companions: Bluebells, wood anemones, violets, ferns — classic native woodland-floor and hedge-bank planting.

West of Ireland: One of Ireland's most familiar native spring wildflowers, found throughout hedge banks and woodland; pale yellow flowers from late winter into spring. Easy, long-lived, and self-seeds gently to form drifts under trees, shrubs and hedges.

16. Round-Lobed Hepatica (*Hepatica nobilis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Round-Lobed Hepatica — view source](#)

Light: ☂ Partial to full shade; ideal under deciduous trees.

Soil needs: Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil, tolerant of neutral to slightly alkaline; pH 6.0-7.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould/compost and a little grit.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; resents disturbance once established.

Spacing: 15-20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould mulch.

Companions: Snowdrops, hellebores, wood anemones — classic very-early-spring woodland-floor planting.

West of Ireland: One of the earliest woodland perennials to flower, with delicate blue, pink or white blooms often appearing before the leaves in late winter/early spring, followed by attractive lobed evergreen foliage. Slow-growing but long-lived once settled — best left undisturbed.

17. St Patrick's Cabbage (*Saxifraga spathularis*)

 **Reference photo:** [St Patrick's Cabbage — view source](#)

Light: ☂ Partial shade to full shade; also tolerates exposed, unshaded mountain sites in its native range.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, acid soil among rocks; pH 5.0-6.0.

Soil prep: Mix clay with 30-40% ericaceous compost/leaf mould and some grit — best replicating a humid, rocky woodland or streamside setting.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; shallow, stoloniferous rooting.

Spacing: 15-20cm between plants

Fertiliser: Very little required. Light ericaceous feed in spring if growth is poor.

Companions: Ferns, mosses, other Irish native rock/woodland plants for an authentic west of Ireland native rockery or shaded bank.

West of Ireland: A true west of Ireland native and local treasure — part of the “Lusitanian flora” found naturally only in Ireland and parts of Portugal/Spain, most abundant in Kerry and west Cork on shaded, humid rocks and hedge banks. An excellent, genuinely native choice for a shaded rockery or damp stone wall in this guide’s own region. Evergreen rosettes of fleshy leaves with delicate white, pink-speckled flowers in early summer.

18. Tasmanian Tree Fern (*Dicksonia antarctica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Dicksonia antarctica \(Tasmanian Tree Fern\) — view source](#)

Light: ☁ Partial to full shade; shelter from direct hot sun and, importantly, from cold drying winds.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, free-draining, slightly acid soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Needs consistent moisture at the crown and root zone but good drainage — dislikes both drought and waterlogging.

Soil prep: Mix clay with generous compost/leaf mould (40%+) and grit. In a container, use a peat-free ericaceous or woodland-type compost mix.

Planting depth: Trunk (caudex) at same depth as previously grown; the fibrous “trunk” is actually a mass of roots and needs to stay moist.

Spacing: 1.5–3m between plants; wrap crown in hard frost

Fertiliser: Balanced liquid feed watered into the crown monthly through the growing season. Regular watering — including watering directly into the crown in dry spells — is more important than feeding.

Companions: Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops — classic damp, shaded woodland-garden planting.

West of Ireland: RHS hardiness H4–H5 (borderline, roughly to –5°C, less with protection); the mild, humid west of Ireland climate suits it well in a sheltered spot, but in harder winters wrap the crown with fleece or straw. Water the crown regularly in the growing season — this is the single most common cause of failure when it is allowed to dry out.

19. Wood Sorrel (*Oxalis acetosella*)

 **Reference photo:** [Wood Sorrel — view source](#)

Light: ● Full shade to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist, humus-rich, acid to neutral soil; pH 5.0–6.5.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leaf mould/compost.

Planting depth: Crown/rhizome at soil level.

Spacing: 10–15cm between plants

Fertiliser: None required.

Companions: Ferns, mosses, primroses — classic deep-woodland-floor groundcover, often found growing directly among tree roots and on old stumps.

West of Ireland: A dainty native woodland groundcover with clover-like leaves that fold down at night and delicate white, purple-veined flowers in spring. Spreads gently by rhizomes to form soft carpets in deep shade where little else will grow — ideal under mature trees or in a native woodland-style corner.

GROUP J: POND & WATER PLANTS

J1. Bog Asphodel (*Narthecium ossifragum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Bog Asphodel — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Soil needs: Permanently wet, humus-rich, nutrient-poor, acid soil/peat; pH 4.5–6.0.

Soil prep: No amendment with compost or fertiliser — this plant is adapted to nutrient-poor bog conditions and rich soil is counterproductive. Best in a boggy, permanently wet corner or the very shallow, saturated margin of a pond.

Planting depth: Crown/rhizome at soil surface, kept permanently wet.

Spacing: 20–30cm between plants; needs permanently wet acid soil

Fertiliser: None — bog asphodel is adapted to nutrient-poor conditions.

Companions: Bogbean, bog pimpernel, sphagnum-type damp margin planting.

West of Ireland: Widespread in Irish bogs, heaths and moorland, with spikes of bright yellow, star-shaped flowers in summer turning deep orange in autumn. A specialist for a genuinely boggy, acid, permanently wet spot rather than an ordinary border or standard pond margin.

⚠ Foliage is toxic to livestock if grazed in quantity; not a concern for typical garden use, but worth knowing if animals have access.

J2. Bog Pimpernel (*Anagallis tenella*)

 **Reference photo:** [Bog Pimpernel — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun.

Spacing: 30–40cm apart; spreads as carpet

Soil needs: Grow in the damp margin to level with the water surface. Moderately fertile, moist but not deeply submerged. Damp margins, bog gardens, very shallow water.

Water depth: Surface moisture to very shallow water (0–5cm at most). Primarily a bog and wet-margin plant.

Planting: Remove from aquatic basket/pot and plant directly into damp boggy soil at the water's edge, or at the very margin of a pond.

Fertiliser: Minimal — adapted to low-nutrient bog conditions. No feeding required if in naturally boggy soil. A light liquid balanced feed monthly if in a container situation will maintain good growth.

Companions: Bogbean, yellow flag iris, water mint, native mosses, royal fern at pond margins. This spreading, native plant forms a dense carpet of tiny evergreen leaves, mixed with numerous rosy pink flowers from late spring to early summer.

West of Ireland: A native Irish plant of damp, slightly acidic marshes, flush grasslands, and lake margins. Particularly common in the west of Ireland, where it grows in abundance in the Burren and Connaught margins. Its natural conditions are replicated in any consistently damp, open, sunny spot near water.

J3. Bogbean (*Menyanthes trifoliata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Bogbean — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Full sun preferred to encourage flowering.

Spacing: 60cm between plants; spreads indefinitely without basket

Soil needs: Shallow water or boggy mud. Grow in baskets in a large pond in water up to 25cm deep, or grow in muddy pool margins.

Water depth: Planting depth: up to 20cm (8 inches) deep in water. Alternatively, in boggy soil at the water's edge with consistent moisture.

Basket size: Recommend a planting basket of at least 19cm across for one plant, or for more impact, plant several of the same variety in a larger basket.

Planting: Place the *Menyanthes* in a container or directly in the soil, making sure that the roots plus about 2 inches of the plant's stem is in the soil and at least an inch of water.

Fertiliser: Very low-maintenance; requires little feeding. Aquatic fertiliser tablet in the basket compost at the start of each growing season is sufficient. The plant is adapted to naturally nutrient-poor bog conditions.

Companions: White water lily, yellow flag iris, bog pimpernel. Bogbean will spread indefinitely by its thick pink rhizomes if not planted in an aquatic basket. Keep in a basket in smaller ponds. Bogbean provides excellent habitat for dragonfly adults and larvae as well as a host of other semi-aquatic invertebrates. Flowers attract bumblebees.

West of Ireland: A native Irish plant of bogs, fens, and lake margins. In nature, bogbean only occurs in bogs and fens, making it a diagnostic species of these important habitats. Completely at home in the west of Ireland — may self-establish naturally in or beside garden ponds.

J4. Marsh Marigold (*Caltha palustris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Marsh Marigold — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Permanently moist to wet soil, or shallow water; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates heavy clay very well.

Soil prep: Little needed — thrives in the wet margins many other plants struggle with.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level, in boggy ground or shallow water 0–10cm deep (in an aquatic basket if planted directly in a pond).

Spacing: 30–40cm between plants

Fertiliser: Little required in a natural pond margin; balanced aquatic fertiliser tablet if grown in a basket.

Companions: Yellow flag iris, bogbean, ferns — classic pond-margin planting.

West of Ireland: Cheerful, bright yellow, buttercup-like flowers in spring at the water's edge; one of the easiest and most reliable native pond-margin perennials for the consistently damp west of Ireland climate.

J5. Marsh Orchids (*Dactylorhiza* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Marsh Orchids — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade, provided the soil stays consistently moist.

Soil needs: Consistently moist, humus-rich soil; slightly acid to neutral (some species tolerate alkaline), pH 6.0–7.0.

Soil prep: Improve clay with leafy compost; avoid manure or very rich feeds, which encourage weeds and disrupt the orchid's root/fungal relationship. Never allow the site to dry out, especially in the growing season.

Planting depth: Tubers 5–8cm deep, or plant nursery-grown pot plants at pot level.

Spacing: 15–20cm between plants; buy nursery stock only

Fertiliser: Little to none required — rich feeding is unhelpful and can encourage competing weeds.

Companions: Damp meadow and pond-margin planting with yellow flag iris, meadowsweet, ragged robin.

West of Ireland: Several marsh orchid species are native to Ireland, found in damp meadows, fens and dune slacks. Always buy nursery-propagated plants (never collected from the wild) and give them a permanently moist, undisturbed spot — a damp meadow or pond margin suits them far better than a conventional border.

J6. Meadowsweet (*Filipendula ulmaria*)

 **Reference photo:** [Meadowsweet — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Does best in a humus-rich moist well-drained soil in semi-shade or in full sun if the soil is kept moist throughout the growing season. It does not tolerate dry or acid soils; however, it does grow well in heavy clay soils.

Soil needs: Moist, fertile soil. Meadowsweet prefers a pH level between 5.0 and 6.5. If your soil is heavy or clay-based, amend it with organic matter to improve drainage. Ideal for boggy areas, pond edges, and consistently damp borders.

Soil prep: For in-ground planting, dig in generous compost. No grit needed — meadowsweet actually prefers moisture-retentive conditions. For very wet areas, plant directly without amendment.

Planting depth: Simply bury the roots up to the crown of the stem in rich soil. Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 60cm between plants; can self-seed

Fertiliser: Feed in spring with a balanced fertiliser to encourage vigorous growth. Deadhead spent flowers to prolong bloom, and cut back the stems to ground level after flowering to keep the plant tidy and encourage fresh foliage. Annual compost mulch. Low-maintenance overall.

Companions: Yellow flag iris, bogbean, royal fern, astilbe, primulas at pond margins or in damp borders. Borders (rear), naturalized areas, wet meadows or moist areas along streams or ponds. Attracts butterflies, bees and beneficial insects very effectively.

West of Ireland: Meadowsweet is native throughout Ireland and wildly abundant in wet western meadows, roadside ditches, and riverside habitats. It is perfectly adapted to the Irish climate and particularly thrives in the wet conditions of the west. One of the most rewarding native plants for a damp or boggy garden.

J7. Native Irish White Water Lily (*Nymphaea alba*)

 **Reference photo:** [Native Irish White Water Lily — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun essential — needs maximum sunshine for flowers to open. Plant in the sunniest spot in the pond.

Spacing: 1.5–2m between plants; large ponds only

Soil needs: Aquatic compost in mesh baskets. Loamy, clay-based aquatic soil is ideal. Do not use multipurpose/garden compost (too rich — promotes algae). Cover with lime-free pea gravel.

Water depth: Best grown about 1 metre deep, but it can grow in up to 3 metres of water if allowed to adjust very gradually. Start shallower (20–30cm) and lower the basket gradually as the plant grows.

Basket size: Recommend a planting basket of at least 22cm across initially; pot up to 30–40cm+ basket as the plant grows. *N. alba* is vigorous — suitable for large ponds and lakes only. Not suitable for small garden ponds.

Planting: Plant the rhizome level with the top of the aquatic compost. Top with lime-free pea gravel. Place basket in pond at shallow depth first; gradually lower to final depth as leaves grow.

Fertiliser: Feed during the growing season with a proprietary aquatic fertiliser at the manufacturer's recommended rate. Use only aquatic fertiliser tablets pushed into the compost — never loose fertiliser into pond water (causes algae bloom). Feed at the start of each growing season.

Companions: Nymphaea alba is Ireland’s only true native water lily. Ideal with Irish natives: Yellow Flag Iris, Bogbean, Bog Pimpernel and meadowsweet at the margins. Water lily pads provide vital shade for fish and wildlife, and reduce algae. Plant oxygenating plants (hornwort, water crowfoot) in the same pond to maintain water quality.

West of Ireland: The moist, mild Atlantic climate is ideal for water lilies. Do not plant near a pump or fountain — water lilies require still water and must not have water splashed onto their floating leaves. Keep leaves dry.

J8. Yellow Flag Iris (*Iris pseudacorus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Yellow Flag Iris — view on Wikipedia](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ light/partial shade. Full sun produces best flowering.

Soil needs: Moist to wet rich soil; pond margin/bog zone with 0–20cm of water over the soil surface or in reliably damp ground. Plant in an aquatic basket with aquatic compost at the margin.

Water depth: 0–20cm of water above the soil/crown; can grow in up to 25–30cm depth. Also grows directly in boggy ground without standing water.

Basket size: 19–24cm diameter aquatic basket; or plant directly into boggy clay at pond margins.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level; set basket so water is 0–20cm above soil surface.

Spacing: 30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs

Fertiliser: Use aquatic fertiliser tablets pushed into the basket compost at the start of each growing season. Very vigorous once established — dividing the clump every 2–3 years in spring is the most important maintenance.

Companions: White water lily, bogbean, bog pimpernel, meadowsweet, royal fern at pond/boggy margins. Dense clumps give refuge for amphibians and emergent support for dragonflies — beds of yellow flag are valuable habitat along wet edges.

⚠ Contact with its juices can cause skin irritations — wear gloves when handling. ⚠ Yellow flag iris spreads by rhizomes and seeds and can quickly overtake native plants in wet sites. Keep in aquatic baskets to control spread in smaller ponds.

West of Ireland: A native Irish plant found wild in fens, marshes, and river margins throughout Ireland. One of the most reliable and beautiful marginal pond plants for Irish conditions.

J9. Yellow Loosestrife (*Lysimachia vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Yellow Loosestrife — view source](#)

Light: ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

Soil needs: Moist to wet soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates heavy clay very well.

Soil prep: Little needed — thrives in damp ground.

Planting depth: Crown at soil level.

Spacing: 40–50cm between plants; spreads by rhizome

Fertiliser: Little required in reasonably fertile damp ground.

Companions: Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris, marsh marigold — classic pond-margin/damp border companions.

West of Ireland: Tall, upright spikes of bright yellow flowers in summer at the water’s edge; spreads by rhizomes to form good-sized clumps in consistently damp ground, so give it room or a contained spot in a smaller pond margin.

COMPLETE REFERENCE TABLE

(Sorted alphabetically by English name across all groups; ID prefix shows which group each plant belongs to.)

Light: ☀ = full sun | ☁ = sun/partial shade | ☂ = partial shade preferred | ● = shade tolerant/full shade **In Pot?:** ✓ = excellent/recommended | ⚠ = possible with care | ✗ = not suitable **Pot size given where relevant**

#	English Name	Latin Name	pH	Planting Depth	In Pot?	Light	Key Companions	Spacing
E1	Acidanthera / Abyssinian Gladiolus	<i>Gladiolus murielae</i>	6.0–7.0	10–16cm on bed of sharp sand	✓ 30cm / 15L+	☀	Salvias, gladioli, dahlias, ornamental grasses	15–20cm between corms
F22	Aconitum (Monkshood)	<i>Aconitum napellus</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	⚠ 20–30L container	☂ to ☀	Delphiniums, hostas, astilbe	45–60cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, wear gloves
F26	Adonis	<i>Adonis vernalis</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 10–15L container	☀ to ☂	Snowdrops, hellebores	20–30cm between plants; ⚠ toxic
E14	Allium	<i>Allium</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	10–15cm deep (2–3x)	✓ 5L+ per bulb cluster	☀	Roses, peonies, irises, ornamental	10–20cm between bulbs

				bulb depth)			grasses	depending on variety
B1	Apple 'Baya Marisa' (P22)	<i>Malus domestica</i>	6.0–7.0	Graft union at/above soil	△ Half-barrel (50L+)	*	Chives, garlic, nasturtiums	1–1.5m between trees; permanent stake
F6	Aquilegia (Columbine)	<i>Aquilegia vulgaris</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 15–20L container	* to 🍄	Foxgloves, hardy geraniums, roses	30–45cm between plants; self-seeds freely
F1	Astilbe	<i>Astilbe</i> spp.	5.5–7.0	At pot level; crown at surface	✓ 40–50cm / 30L+	🍄	Hostas, ferns, hellebores, primulas	30–45cm between plants
F2	Auricula	<i>Primula auricula</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 3–5L pot/trough	🍄	Saxifrage, sempervivum, other alpiners	15–20cm between plants
A1	Bamboo (clump-forming)	<i>Fargesia</i> / <i>Chusquea</i> spp.	5.5–7.0	At pot level	△ Very large tub (100L+)	🍄	Ferns, hostas, astilbe	1.5–3m from structures; root barrier for running types
F3	Bearded Iris (Border Iris)	<i>Iris germanica</i>	6.5–7.5	Rhizome at/just above soil surface	△ Wide shallow container, 30L+	*	Roses, peonies, alliums	30–45cm between rhizomes; divide every 3–4 yrs
B2	Blackberries	<i>Rubus fruticosus</i> agg.	5.5–7.0	At nursery soil mark	△ 40–50L container against support	* to 🍄	Raspberries, other cane fruit	2–3m between plants against wires
B3	Blackcurrant	<i>Ribes nigrum</i>	6.0–7.0	5–7cm deeper than nursery mark	△ 30L+ large pot	🍄	Alliums, garlic, nasturtiums, redcurrant	1.2–1.5m between plants
F4	Blue Gentian	<i>Gentiana</i> spp.	5.5–6.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 10–15L container	* to 🍄	Heather, dwarf conifers, saxifrage	20–30cm between plants
B4	Blueberry	<i>Vaccinium corymbosum</i>	4.0–5.5	At pot level	✓ Essential: 40–60cm / 30–50L+	🍄	Heather, lingonberry (same ericaceous trough)	1 plant per pot; 60cm between pots
J1	Bog Asphodel	<i>Narhecium ossifragum</i>	4.5–6.0	Crown at soil surface, permanently wet	△ Bog garden/boggy pot only	*	Bogbean, bog pimpernel	20–30cm between plants; needs permanently wet acid soil
J2	Bog Pimpernel	<i>Anagallis tenella</i>	5.0–6.5	Crown at soil surface; bog margin to waterline	✓ Small shallow container at margin	*	Bogbean, yellow flag iris, water mint	30–40cm apart; spreads as carpet
J3	Bogbean / Buckbean	<i>Menyanthes trifoliata</i>	5.0–7.5	Roots + 5cm stem in soil; 5–25cm water above	✓ 19–24cm+ aquatic basket	*	White water lily, yellow flag iris, bog pimpernel	60cm between plants; spreads indefinitely without basket
A2	Border Forsythia	<i>Forsythia</i> × <i>intermedia</i>	6.0–8.0	At pot level	✗ Too large	🍄	Spring tulips, Vinca, holly backdrop	1.5m between; 2m from walls
G3	Briza Maxima (Quaking Grass)	<i>Briza maxima</i>	6.0–7.5	5mm deep (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	*	Cornflower, poppies, love-in-a-mist	15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds
C9	Campanula saxifraga	<i>Campanula saxifraga</i>	6.5–7.5	At pot level	✓ Trough/rockery, 3–5L	*	Sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort	15–20cm between plants
H1	Catnip	<i>Nepeta cataria</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✓ 15–20L container	* to 🍄	Brassicas, roses	30–45cm between plants
A3	Cherry Blossom 'Kanzan'	<i>Prunus</i> 'Kanzan'	6.0–7.5	Graft union at/above soil	△ 100L+ container	*	Daffodils, forget-me-nots, hostas	4–5m from trees/structures
G1	Chinese Pink	<i>Dianthus chinensis</i>	6.5–7.5	3mm deep (seed) / at pot level	✓ 5L+ container	*	Cornflower, love-in-a-mist	15–20cm between plants; grow as annual/biennial
D2	Clematis (most)	<i>Clematis</i> spp.	6.5–7.5	10–15cm DEEPER than pot	✓ 45cm/40L+ container	🍄 (roots shaded)	Climbing roses, other clematis	60–90cm between; cool roots essential
D3	Climbing Honeysuckle	<i>Lonicera periclymenum</i>	5.5–8.0	At pot level	△ 30L+ (not ideal, deep roots)	🍄	Climbing roses, clematis; near windows	1.5m between plants
D4	Climbing Hydrangea	<i>Hydrangea anomala</i> subsp. <i>petiolaris</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level	△ 50L+ (not ideal)	● to 🍄	Ivy, ferns, hostas, shade-tolerant plants	45cm from wall; 60cm+ between plants
D5	Climbing Roses	<i>Rosa</i> (climbing cvs.)	6.0–7.0	Graft union just below soil	△ 50L+ large container	*	Clematis (same wall), lavender, geraniums	45cm from wall; 2–3m between plants
F5	Clustered Bellflower	<i>Campanula glomerata</i>	6.5–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 15–20L container	* to 🍄	Roses, peonies, ornamental	30–40cm between plants;

							grasses	divide every 3-4 yrs
I1	Common Dog Violet	<i>Viola riviniana</i>	5.5-7.0	Crown at soil level	✓ 5L+ container	🍄	Primroses, wood sorrel, ferns	15-20cm between plants
A4	Common Hawthorn	<i>Crataegus monogyna</i>	5.5-7.5	At nursery soil mark	✗ Too large for pots	* to 🍄	Blackthorn, holly, hazel; primroses, bluebells beneath	As hedge: 30-45cm; as tree: 4-6m from structures
I3	Convallaria (Lily of the Valley)	<i>Convallaria majalis</i>	6.0-7.5	2-3cm deep (rhizome)	✓ 15-20L container	🍄	Ferns, hostas, hellebores	15-20cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, spreads
F7	Coral Bells	<i>Heuchera</i> spp.	6.0-7.0	Crown at soil level	✓ 20-30L container	🍄	Hostas, astilbe, ferns, hellebores	30-45cm between plants
H2	Coriander	<i>Coriandrum sativum</i>	6.0-7.0	Sow 5mm deep; do not transplant	✓ 20cm+ deep / 5L+	🍄	Parsley, brassicas; away from dill & fennel	15-20cm between plants
G2	Cornflower	<i>Centaurea cyanus</i>	6.0-7.5	1-2cm deep (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	*	Poppies, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima	20-30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds
B5	Cranberry	<i>Vaccinium macrocarpon</i>	4.0-5.0	At pot level	✓ Essential: 30-45cm / 10-20L	🍄	Heather, lingonberry, blueberry (ericaceous)	30-45cm in acidic bed
C2	Creeping / Moss Phlox	<i>Phlox subulata</i>	5.5-7.7	At pot level; shoots above soil	✓ 20-30cm / 5-10L + grit	*	Tulips, daffodils underplanted; thyme, sedum, dianthus	30-45cm for ground cover
C1	Creeping Juniper	<i>Juniperus horizontalis</i>	4.5-8.5	At pot level or slightly raised	✓ 30-40cm/20L+	* (essential)	Heather, sedum, ornamental grasses, thyme	1-1.5m for ground cover
E5	Crocus	<i>Crocus</i> spp.	6.0-7.5	7-12cm deep; pointed end up	✓ Excellent: 15-20cm / 3L+	* (most) / 🍄	Snowdrops, daffodils, muscari, aconites	8-9cm between corms
E6	Crown Imperial	<i>Fritillaria imperialis</i>	6.5-8.0	20-30cm deep, planted on its side	⚠ 40cm / 30L+ deep pot	*	Tulips, alliums, wallflowers, euphorbia	25cm between bulbs
H3	Cucumbers	<i>Cucumis sativus</i>	6.0-7.0	At pot level (after frost)	✓ Large 30-40L container with support	*	Nasturtiums, dill, sweetcorn	45-60cm between plants
E7	Daffodil	<i>Narcissus</i> spp.	6.0-7.0	15cm (3x bulb height)	✓ 20-30cm / 5L+	🍄	Snowdrops, tulips, forget-me-nots, Muscari	10-15cm between bulbs
F9	Daylilies	<i>Hemerocallis</i> spp.	6.0-7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 20-30L container	* to 🍄	Roses, ornamental grasses, yarrow	45-60cm between plants; divide every 3-4 yrs
I4c	Deer Fern	<i>Blechnum spicant</i>	4.5-6.0	At pot level	✓ 30cm / 10L+	🍄 to ●	Lingonberry, heather, foxgloves	30-45cm between plants
F10	Delphinium	<i>Delphinium</i> spp.	6.5-7.5	At pot level; buds 2-5cm below	⚠ 40-50cm / 40L+	*	Roses, lupins, peonies, alliums	60-90cm between plants; stake essential
I8	Dicksonia antarctica (Tree Fern)	<i>Dicksonia antarctica</i>	5.5-6.5	Trunk at same depth as grown	✓ Large 50L+ container	🍄 to ●	Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops	1.5-3m between plants; wrap crown in hard frost
H4	Dill	<i>Anethum graveolens</i>	5.5-7.0	Sow 3-5mm deep; do not transplant	✓ 30cm+ deep / 8L+	*	Brassicas, lettuce; away from coriander & fennel	20-30cm between plants
E8	Dwarf Iris	<i>Iris reticulata</i>	6.0-7.5	8-10cm deep	✓ 3-5L pot/trough	*	Snowdrops, crocus, dwarf daffodils	5-8cm between bulbs
A5	Dwarf Lily Magnolia	<i>Magnolia liliiflora</i>	5.5-6.5	At nursery soil mark	⚠ 50-80L container	* to 🍄	Hellebores, ferns, snowdrops, Japanese maple	2-3m between plants/structures
F11	Edelweiss	<i>Leontopodium alpinum</i>	6.5-7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ Trough/rockery, 5L	*	Sempervivum, saxifrage, other alpine	15-20cm between plants
F12	Elephant's Ears	<i>Bergenia</i> spp.	5.5-8.0	Rhizome at/just below surface	✓ 25-35cm / 10L+	● to *	Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops, ferns	30-60cm between plants
F14	Foxglove	<i>Digitalis purpurea</i>	5.5-7.5	At pot level; seeds on surface	✓ 30cm / 10L+ deep	🍄	Ferns, hostas, roses, alliums; self-seeds	30-45cm between plants
E9	Freesia	<i>Freesia</i> spp.	6.0-7.0	5-8cm deep	✓ Best in containers (tender)	*	Ixia and other tender corms	5-8cm between corms
E3	Fritillaria meleagris (Checkered Lily)	<i>Fritillaria meleagris</i>	6.0-7.0	10cm deep	✓ 5L+ container	🍄	Snowdrops, daffodils, damp border/pond-margin planting	8-10cm between bulbs

A7	Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester	<i>Deutzia scabra</i>	6.0-7.5	At nursery soil mark	△ Large 80-100L container	* to 🍂	Mock orange, lilac, weigela, spring bulbs	1.5-2m between plants; grows 1.8-3m tall
E21	Gagea (Yellow Star-of-Bethlehem)	<i>Gagea lutea</i>	6.5-7.5	5-8cm deep	✓ 5L+ container	🍂	Snowdrops, wood anemones	5-8cm between bulbs
B6	Garden Plum	<i>Prunus domestica</i>	6.0-7.0	Graft union at/above soil	△ Half-barrel (50L+)	*	Chives, garlic, comfrey, nasturtiums	3-5m between trees depending on rootstock; permanent stake
B7	Gooseberry	<i>Ribes uva-crispa</i>	6.0-7.5	At nursery mark; roots 5cm	△ 30L+ large pot	🍂	Redcurrant, whitecurrant, tansy	1.5m between plants
H5	Green Onions (Scallions)	<i>Allium fistulosum</i>	6.0-7.0	1cm deep (seed) / at pot level	✓ 5L+ container	* to 🍂	Carrots, rocket, radish	5-8cm between plants; sow successionally
D6	Hardy Grapes	<i>Vitis vinifera</i>	6.0-6.5	At pot depth; graft above soil	△ 40L+ container	* (essential)	Lavender, rosemary, garlic, hyssop	1.2-1.5m between vines; 20cm from wall
C3	Heather / Scots Heather	<i>Calluna vulgaris</i>	4.5-6.5 (ideally 5.5)	At pot level	✓ 20-25cm / 5-10L ericaceous compost	*	Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses	30-45cm between plants
F16	Hellebore / Lenten Rose	<i>Helleborus</i> spp.	6.0-8.0	At pot level; crown at/just below	✓ 25-35cm / 10L+	🍂 to ●	Snowdrops, cyclamen, pulmonaria, hostas	45-60cm between plants
A8	Holly	<i>Ilex aquifolium</i>	4.5-8.0	At pot level (shallow roots)	△ 50L+ container	● to *	Yew, forsythia, hellebores; plant ♂ + ♀ for berries	1.5-3m between; slow-growing hedge
B8	Honeyberry (Kamchatka)	<i>Lonicera caerulea</i> var. <i>kamtschatica</i>	4.5-7.5	At pot level	△ 50-75L (15-20 gal.)	🍂	Blueberry, lingonberry; needs 2+ varieties	1-1.5m between plants
D7	Hops	<i>Humulus lupulus</i>	6.0-8.0	Rhizome 5-8cm / pot level	✓ 50L+ large container	🍂	Climbing roses, clematis, ornamental grasses	1-1.5m between plants
F17	Hosta / Plantain Lily	<i>Hosta</i> spp.	6.0-8.0	At pot level; crown at surface	✓ 30-60cm / 20-50L+	🍂 to ●	Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia	30-90cm (variety-dependent)
A17	Hypericum 'Rowallane'	<i>Hypericum</i> 'Rowallane'	5.5-7.5	At nursery soil mark	△ 40-50L container	* to 🍂	Heather, skimmia, roses, late perennials	1-1.5m between plants
I2	Irish Native Mosses	<i>various spp.</i>	5.0-6.5 (most)	Surface transplant, not buried	✓ Shallow tray/log/pot	🍂 to ●	Ferns, wood sorrel, primroses	Establish as patches; keep consistently moist
A9	Irish Yew	<i>Taxus baccata</i> 'Fastigiata'	5.0-8.0	At pot level	△ 50L+ container	● to *	Holly, peonies, roses (backdrop), hellebores	Column 1m wide eventually; 1m from structures
E10	Iron Cross (Oxalis)	<i>Oxalis tetraphylla</i> 'Iron Cross'	6.0-7.0	5cm deep	✓ 3-5L container	* to 🍂	Ixia, dwarf dahlias, other summer bulbs	10-15cm between tubers; lift over winter
D8	Ivy	<i>Hedera helix</i> / <i>H. hibernica</i>	5.0-8.0	At pot level	✓ 20L+ (25-35cm pot)	● to *	Virginia creeper, ferns, snowdrops, bluebells	30-50cm between plants
E4	Ixia	<i>Ixia</i> spp.	6.0-7.0	8-10cm deep	✓ Best in containers (borderline hardy)	*	Freesia and other tender corms	5-8cm between corms
E2b	Japanese / Autumn Anemone	<i>Anemone × hybrida</i>	6.0-7.5	At pot level	✓ 40-50cm / 30L+	🍂	Hostas, astilbe, hellebores	45-60cm between plants; can spread
A10	Japanese Camellia	<i>Camellia japonica</i>	5.0-6.5	At nursery soil mark	✓ 40-50L ericaceous compost	🍂	Skimmia, hydrangea macrophylla, Japanese maple	1-1.5m between plants
A11	Japanese Maple	<i>Acer palmatum</i>	5.5-6.5	At pot level (shallow)	✓ 50-80L terracotta/stone	🍂	Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops	2-4m from structures; wind shelter essential
A12	Japanese Skimmia	<i>Skimmia japonica</i>	5.5-6.5	At nursery soil mark	✓ 30-40L container	● to *	Hellebores, ferns, hostas, Japanese maple	60-90cm between plants; ♂+♀ within a few metres for berries
F18	Lady's Bedstraw	<i>Galium verum</i>	6.0-7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 5L+ container	*	Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wild grasses	20-30cm between plants
H6	Lavender	<i>Lavandula angustifolia</i>	6.5-8.0	At pot level	✓ Terracotta 20-30L, with grit	*	Roses, rosemary, thyme	30-45cm between plants
A13	Lewis Mock	<i>Philadelphus</i>	6.0-7.5	At nursery soil	△ 50L+	* to 🍂	Deutzia, lilac,	1.5-2m between

	Orange	<i>lewisii</i>		mark	container		roses, spring bulbs	plants
A14	Lilac	<i>Syringa vulgaris</i>	6.5-8.0	At nursery soil mark	✗ Too large	*	Roses, alliums, peonies, irises	1.5m between; 2m from walls
E11	Lily	<i>Lilium</i> spp.	6.0-7.0	15cm (3× bulb height) on grit	✓ 30-40cm / 15-25L	🌱	Hostas, geraniums, roses, alliums	15-30cm between bulbs
F19	Lilyleaf Ladybells	<i>Adenophora liliifolia</i>	6.0-7.5	Crown at soil level	△ 20L+ container (dislikes disturbance)	* to 🌱	Bellflowers, delphiniums, phlox	30-40cm between plants
B9	Lingonberry	<i>Vaccinium vitis-idaea</i>	4.2-5.5	At pot level	✓ 25-30cm / 10-15L	🌱	Blueberry, heather, cranberry, deer fern	30cm between plants
F25	Linum (Perennial Flax)	<i>Linum perenne</i>	6.0-7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 10-15L container	*	Yarrow, lavender, drought-tolerant perennials	20-30cm between plants
G5	Love-in-a-Mist	<i>Nigella damascena</i>	6.0-7.5	1cm deep (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	* to 🌱	Cornflower, poppies, briza maxima	20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely
F20	Lungworts	<i>Pulmonaria</i> spp.	6.0-7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 15-20L container	🌱	Hellebores, ferns, hostas	30-40cm between plants; divide every 3-4 yrs
F21	Lupins	<i>Lupinus polyphyllus</i>	5.5-6.5	Crown at soil level	△ 20L+ container (dislikes disturbance)	* to 🌱	Delphiniums, roses, foxgloves	45-60cm between plants
I4a	Male Fern	<i>Dryopteris filix-mas</i>	5.0-7.0	Crown 7-12cm above soil	✓ 40-50cm / 30L+	🌱 to ●	Hostas, astilbe, bamboo, snowdrops	60-90cm between plants
J4	Marsh Marigold	<i>Caltha palustris</i>	6.0-7.5	Crown at soil level / shallow water	✓ Aquatic basket, 3-5L	* to 🌱	Yellow flag iris, bogbean, ferns	30-40cm between plants
J5	Marsh Orchids	<i>Dactylorhiza</i> spp.	6.0-7.0	5-8cm deep (tuber) / at pot level	△ Large container, kept constantly moist	* to 🌱	Yellow flag iris, meadowsweet, ragged robin	15-20cm between plants; buy nursery stock only
E12	Martagon Lily	<i>Lilium martagon</i>	6.0-7.5	15cm deep (3× bulb height)	✓ Large 20L+ container	🌱	Hostas, ferns, hellebores; light woodland edge	20-30cm between bulbs
J6	Meadowsweet	<i>Filipendula ulmaria</i>	5.0-6.5	Crown at soil level	△ Large 40-50cm / 30L+	* to 🌱	Yellow flag iris, bogbean, royal fern, astilbe	60cm between plants; can self-seed
H7	Melissa (Lemon Balm)	<i>Melissa officinalis</i>	6.0-7.5	At pot level	✓ 15-20L container (to contain spread)	* to 🌱	Brassicas, tomatoes	30-45cm between plants; spreads readily
H8	Mint	<i>Mentha</i> spp.	6.0-7.0	At pot level	✓ Essential (contains spread): 30cm / 10L+	🌱	Near brassicas/tomatoes as repellent (in pots)	60cm if in ground with root barrier
A15	Mophead / Lacecap Hydrangea	<i>Hydrangea macrophylla</i>	5.0-7.0 (blue 5.0-6.0; pink 6.0-7.0)	At pot level; rootball top slightly raised	✓ Excellent: 40cm compact / 50-60cm standard	🌱	Astilbe, hostas, ferns, yarrow, heucheras	90cm-2.4m between (check label for variety size)
H9	Mother of Thyme	<i>Thymus serpyllum</i>	6.0-8.0	At pot level	✓ Terracotta 20cm / 5L+ with grit	*	Rosemary, oregano, lavender, creeping juniper	20-30cm between plants
A16	Mountain Ash (Rowan)	<i>Sorbus aucuparia</i>	5.0-7.0	At nursery soil mark	△ 80-100L container	* to 🌱	Holly, hawthorn, ferns, foxgloves, hellebores	3-5m from structures
H10	Nasturtiums	<i>Tropaeolum majus</i>	6.0-7.5	1-2cm deep (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	* to 🌱	Apples, brassicas, cucumbers (trap crop)	20-30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds
E13	Native Bluebells	<i>Hyacinthoides non-scripta</i>	6.0-6.8	8cm deep	✓ 5L+ container	🌱	Ferns, hostas, primroses, wood anemones	8-10cm between bulbs
J7	Native White Water Lily	<i>Nymphaea alba</i>	6.5-7.5 (water)	Crown at soil surface in basket; start 20-30cm below water surface, lower to 90-150cm	✓ (pond basket essential): 30-40cm+ basket	*	Yellow flag iris, bogbean, oxygenating plants	1.5-2m between plants; large ponds only
H11	Oregano / Wild Marjoram	<i>Origanum vulgare</i>	6.5-8.0	At pot level	✓ 25cm / 8L+	*	Thyme, rosemary; pollinator attractor for fruit	30-45cm between plants
F13	Paeonia tenuifolia (Fern-leaf Peony)	<i>Paeonia tenuifolia</i>	6.5-7.5	Eyes 2-3cm below soil	△ 30-40L container	*	Alliums, bearded iris, catmint	45-60cm between plants

F23	Pasqueflower	<i>Pulsatilla vulgaris</i>	6.5–8.0	At pot level; do not disturb	✓ Essential on clay: 25–30cm / 10L+	✱	Dianthus, Eryngium, Achillea, ornamental grasses	20–30cm between plants
D1	Passiflora (Blue Passion Flower)	<i>Passiflora caerulea</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery soil mark	△ 40–50L container against support	✱	Climbing roses, clematis, honeysuckle	2–3m between plants against wall/fence
F24	Peony (herbaceous) △	<i>Paeonia</i> spp.	6.5–7.0	Eyes MAX 2.5–5cm below soil	△ 50L+ large tub	✱ to 🍷	Alliums, irises, salvia, roses, foxgloves	90cm between plants
C5	Periwinkle	<i>Vinca minor</i> / <i>V. major</i>	5.5–8.0	At pot level	✓ 25–35cm / 10L+	● to ✱	Hellebores, snowdrops, ivy; under trees/shrubs	30–45cm between plants; can spread
E15	Persian Ranunculus	<i>Ranunculus asiaticus</i>	6.0–7.0	5–8cm deep; claws down	✓ Better in pots: 25–30cm / 10L+	🍷	Pansies, muscari, spring anemones	15–20cm between tubers
G4	Phacelia	<i>Phacelia tanacetifolia</i>	6.0–7.5	1cm deep (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	✱	Vegetable beds, fruit trees (pollinator support)	20–30cm between plants; annual, sow successionally
F27	Pinks	<i>Dianthus plumarius</i> (garden pinks)	5.8–6.5	At pot level	✓ 25–35cm / 10L+	✱	Roses, stocks, alliums, lavender, Phlox subulata	25–35cm between plants
B10	Pomegranate	<i>Punica granatum</i>	5.5–7.0	At nursery soil mark	✓ Large 50L+ container, movable	✱	Passiflora, grapevine on same warm wall	2–3m against wall; borderline hardy, best in a container
G6	Poppies	<i>Papaver rhoeas</i>	6.0–7.5	Surface-sown (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	✱	Cornflower, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima	15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely
C6	Prickly Heath	<i>Gaultheria mucronata</i>	4.5–6.0	At nursery soil mark	✓ 20–30L ericaceous compost	✱ to 🍷	Heather, blueberry, lingonberry, dwarf conifers	45–60cm between plants; ♂+♀ for berries
I5	Primroses	<i>Primula vulgaris</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✓ 10–15L container	🍷	Bluebells, wood anemones, violets, ferns	20–25cm between plants
H12	Radish	<i>Raphanus sativus</i>	6.0–7.0	1cm deep (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	✱ to 🍷	Carrots, lettuce, green onions	2–3cm between plants; sow successionally
B11	Raspberry	<i>Rubus idaeus</i>	5.8–6.5	Crown 5–7cm below soil	✗	🍷	Garlic, marigolds, tansy; away from potatoes	45–60cm between canes; 1.8m between rows
B12	Redcurrant	<i>Ribes rubrum</i>	6.0–7.5	At nursery mark; roots 5cm	△ 30L+ large pot	🍷 (north fence ok)	Gooseberry, whitecurrant	1.5m between plants
C7	Reindeer Lichen	<i>Cladonia rangiferina</i>	4.0–5.5	Surface only, not buried	△ Shallow tray/rockery	✱ to 🍷	Heather, sempervivum, open heath planting	Establishes slowly; avoid disturbance
B13	Rhubarb	<i>Rheum × hybridum</i>	6.0–7.0	Buds 1–2cm below soil	△ 50cm / 50L+ deep pot	🍷	Beans, peas nearby; away from fennel	90cm between crowns
H13	Rocket	<i>Eruca sativa</i>	6.0–7.0	1cm deep (seed)	✓ 5L+ container	✱ to 🍷	Radish, green onions, lettuce	15–20cm between plants; sow successionally
H14	Rosemary	<i>Salvia rosmarinus</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✓ Terracotta 20–30L, with grit	✱	Brassicas, carrots, beans, thyme, lavender	45–60cm between plants
I6	Round-Lobed Hepatica	<i>Hepatica nobilis</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 10–15L container	🍷	Snowdrops, hellebores, wood anemones	15–20cm between plants
I4b	Royal Fern	<i>Osmunda regalis</i>	4.5–6.5	Crown slightly above soil	✗ Too large	✱ to 🍷	Hostas, iris, marginal aquatics, bamboo	1–1.5m between plants
F8	Rudbeckia ‘Goldball’	<i>Rudbeckia laciniata</i> ‘Goldball’	5.5–7.0	At pot level	△ 40–50cm / 40L+ (very tall — better in ground)	✱	Helenium, echinacea, salvias, ornamental grasses, asters	60–90cm between; divide every 2–3 yrs
C8	Saxifrage	<i>Saxifraga</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✓ Trough/rockery, 3–5L	✱ to 🍷	Sempervivum, campanula saxifraga, dwarf bulbs	15–20cm between plants
H15	Scurvy Grass	<i>Cochlearia officinalis</i>	6.5–7.5	At pot level / surface-sown seed	✓ 5L+ container	✱ to 🍷	Sea kale, coastal edible plants	15–20cm between plants
C4	Sempervivum	<i>Sempervivum</i> spp.	6.0–7.5	At pot level	✓ Shallow pot/trough, 3–5L	✱	Saxifrage, wall pennywort, thyme, sedum	10–15cm between rosettes

B14	Serviceberry	<i>Amelanchier lamarckii</i>	5.5–7.0	At nursery soil mark	△ 50–80L container	* to 🍄	Hellebores, snowdrops, ferns, Japanese maple	2–4m between plants/structures
F28	Siberian Statice	<i>Goniolimon tataricum</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 15–20L container	*	Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum	30–40cm between plants
E16	Snowdrop	<i>Galanthus nivalis</i>	5.5–7.0	10cm (dry) / at growing depth (green)	✓ 20–25cm / 5L+	🍄 to ●	Hellebores, aconites, early narcissus, cyclamen coum	8–10cm between bulbs
E17	Snowflake (Summer)	<i>Leucojum aestivum</i>	5.5–7.0	8–10cm deep; in autumn	✓ 30–40cm / 15L+	🍄	Daffodils, snowdrops, hellebores; pond edges	8–10cm between bulbs
A6	Sorbaria sorbifolia	<i>Sorbaria sorbifolia</i>	5.5–7.5	At nursery soil mark	△ 40–50L container	* to 🍄	Hydrangea, deutzia; good bank stabiliser	1–1.5m between plants; spreads by suckers
F29	Spreading Bellflower	<i>Campanula patula</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level / surface-sown seed	✓ 10–15L container	* to 🍄	Ox-eye daisy, wild grasses	20–30cm between plants; biennial/short-lived
E2a	Spring Anemone	<i>Anemone blanda</i> / <i>A. nemorosa</i>	5.5–7.0	5–8cm deep	✓ 20–25cm / 5L+	🍄	Snowdrops, bluebells, foxgloves	10cm between corms
E18	Spring Sowbread (Cyclamen)	<i>Cyclamen coum</i>	6.0–7.5	2–3cm deep, flat side down	✓ 3–5L container	🍄	Snowdrops, winter aconite, hellebores	10–15cm between tubers
I7	St Patrick's Cabbage	<i>Saxifraga spathularis</i>	5.0–6.0	Crown at soil level	✓ 10–15L container/rockery	🍄 to ●	Ferns, native mosses, shaded rockery plants	15–20cm between plants
A18	Star Magnolia	<i>Magnolia stellata</i>	5.0–6.5	At pot level; no deeper	✓ 80–100L stone/terracotta	🍄	Snowdrops, daffodils, hellebores, hardy geraniums	2.5m spread; shelter from N/E winds
F30	Stocks	<i>Matthiola incana</i> / <i>M. longipetala</i>	6.5–7.5	At pot level; seeds on surface	✓ 25–30cm / 10L+	🍄	Wallflowers, sweet William, pansies	20–30cm between plants
B15	Strawberry	<i>Fragaria × ananassa</i>	5.5–6.8	Crown exactly at soil level	✓ 30–35cm / 15–20L per plant	*	Borage, garlic, chives, marigolds	30–45cm between plants
B16	Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia'	<i>Prunus avium</i> 'Sylvia'	6.0–7.0 (well-drained)	~12cm / graft union at soil level	✓ Large patio pot	* to 🍄	Chives, garlic	1m spacing; self-fertile
G7	Sweet Peas	<i>Lathyrus odoratus</i>	6.0–7.5	2cm deep (seed)	✓ Large 20L+ container with support	*	Climbing roses, clematis; vegetable garden	15–20cm between plants against support
F31	Sweet William	<i>Dianthus barbatus</i>	5.8–6.5	At pot level	✓ 25–30cm / 10L+	*	Pinks, stocks, foxgloves, wallflowers, roses	30cm between plants
F32	Toadflax	<i>Linaria vulgaris</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level / surface-sown seed	✓ 5L+ container	* to 🍄	Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wildflower meadow	20–30cm between plants; spreads readily
F15	Trollius (Globeflower)	<i>Trollius europaeus</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✓ 20–30L container, keep moist	* to 🍄	Astilbe, hosta, candelabra primulas	30–40cm between plants
E19	Tulip	<i>Tulipa</i> spp.	6.0–7.0	20cm (3× bulb height)	✓ Excellent: 25–30cm / 10L+	*	Forget-me-nots, daffodils, alliums, wallflowers	10–15cm between bulbs
F33	Vervain	<i>Verbena officinalis</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 10–15L container	* to 🍄	Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses	20–30cm between plants
D9	Vicia (Tufted Vetch)	<i>Vicia cracca</i>	6.0–7.5	1–2cm (seed) / at pot level	✓ 5L+ container	* to 🍄	Grasses, wildflower meadow species, hedgerow shrubs	20–30cm between plants; scrambles via tendrils
D10	Virginia Creeper	<i>Parthenocissus quinquefolia</i>	5.5–7.5	At pot level	✓ 30–40L container	🍄	Ivy (same wall), late clematis	1.5–3m between plants
C10	Wall Pennywort	<i>Umbilicus rupestris</i>	6.0–7.5	At pot level / wall crevice	✓ Small pot or wall crevice	🍄	Ivy, ferns, sempervivum, saxifrage	15–20cm between plants
E20	Wild Tulip	<i>Tulipa sylvestris</i>	6.0–7.5	10–15cm deep	✓ 5L+ container	🍄 to *	Daffodils, other naturalising bulbs	10–15cm between bulbs
D11	Wisteria	<i>Wisteria sinensis</i> / <i>floribunda</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level; graft above soil	△ 45cm/60L+ container	*	Climbing roses (same wall), alliums, irises	45cm from wall; 3m between plants
I9	Wood Sorrel	<i>Oxalis acetosella</i>	5.0–6.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 5L+ container	● to 🍄	Ferns, native mosses, primroses	10–15cm between plants
B17	Woodland Strawberry	<i>Fragaria vesca</i>	5.5–7.0	Crown at soil level	✓ 20–30L container	* to 🍄	Ferns, hostas, primroses	25–30cm between plants; spreads by

								runners
F34	Yarrow	<i>Achillea millefolium</i>	5.5–7.0	At pot level; bare-root buds 2–3cm below	✓ 30cm / 10L+	*	Roses, salvia, echinacea, hydrangea, ornamental grasses	30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs
J8	Yellow Flag Iris	<i>Iris pseudacorus</i>	5.5–8.0	Crown at soil level; 0–20cm water above	✓ 19–24cm aquatic basket	*	White water lily, bogbean, bog pimpernel	30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs
J9	Yellow Loosestrife	<i>Lysimachia vulgaris</i>	6.0–7.5	Crown at soil level	✓ 20L+ container, keep moist	* to ☂	Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris, marsh marigold	40–50cm between plants; spreads by rhizome
H16	Zucchini (Courgette)	<i>Cucurbita pepo</i>	6.0–7.0	At pot level (after frost)	✓ Large 30–40L container	*	Nasturtiums, sweetcorn, beans	60–90cm between plants

KEY GROUPS

Ericaceous plants (acid-lovers — never add lime near these):

Blueberry · Heather (*Calluna vulgaris*) · Heather (*Erica* spp.) · Lingonberry · Cranberry · Japanese Maple (partial) · Deer Fern · Royal Fern · Japanese Skimmia · Dicksonia antarctica (partial) · Japanese Camellia · Prickly Heath · St Patrick's Cabbage

Best clay-tolerant plants on your list:

Virginia Creeper · Ivy · Hops · Bamboo (clump-forming) · Astilbe · Japanese Anemone · Bergenia · Hellebore · Male Fern · Royal Fern · Forsythia · Blackcurrant · Blackberries · Honeyberry · Hostas · Holly · Irish Yew · Climbing Hydrangea · Hydrangea macrophylla · Meadowsweet · Yellow Flag Iris · Snowflake (*Leucojum*) · Periwinkle · Native Bluebells · Daylilies · Common Hawthorn · Mountain Ash (Rowan) · Sorbaria sorbifolia · Marsh Marigold · Trollius · Yellow Loosestrife

Needs raised bed or exceptional drainage on Irish clay:

Rosemary · Lavender · Pasqueflower · Fritillaria imperialis · Acidanthera · Thyme · Creeping Juniper · Ranunculus · Tulips (or annual pots) · Dianthus pinks · Sweet William · Phlox subulata · Bearded Iris · Dwarf Iris · Allium · Sempervivum · Saxifrage · Campanula saxifraga · Edelweiss · Auricula · Siberian Statice · Linum

Must be in containers on wet Irish clay:

Blueberry · Cranberry · Lingonberry (unless naturally acidic area) · Mint (to contain spread) · Melissa/Lemon Balm (to contain spread) · Pasqueflower (strongly recommended) · Ranunculus (best practice) · Rosemary (or raised bed) · Lavender (or raised bed) · Heather (if clay is not acidic enough) · Freesia (tender) · Ixia (borderline hardy) · Iron Cross Oxalis (lift over winter)

Pond/water plants — water depth guide:

- **Deep water (90–150cm):** Native White Water Lily (*Nymphaea alba*)
- **Shallow water (0–25cm) / pond margin:** Yellow Flag Iris, Bogbean, Bog Pimpernel, Marsh Marigold
- **Bog/damp margin (not submerged but consistently moist):** Meadowsweet, Bog Pimpernel, Royal Fern, Astilbe, Trollius, Yellow Loosestrife, Marsh Orchids
- **Permanently wet, acid bog only:** Bog Asphodel

Toxic plants — site away from children, pets and livestock:

Holly (berries) · Irish Yew (all parts except berry flesh) · Snowdrops · Daffodils · Bluebells (native and Spanish) · Fritillaria · Aconitum/Monkshood (all parts, sap irritates skin) · Convallaria/Lily of the Valley (all parts) · Adonis (all parts) · Bog Asphodel (foliage, to livestock) · Japanese Skimmia (berries, mildly)

Sources: RHS Growing Guides (rhs.org.uk), gardens4you.ie product listings (P22 rootstock; Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia'), Future Forests Ireland (futureforests.ie), Irish Seed Savers Association (irishseedsavers.ie), NC State Extension Plant Toolbox (plants.ces.ncsu.edu), Plants For A Future (pfaf.org), Missouri Botanical Garden Plant Finder, BBC Gardeners' World Magazine (gardenersworld.com), Garden UK (gardenuk.co.uk), Thompson & Morgan, Farmer Gracy, Wild Your Garden, Wetland Plants UK, Plants for Ponds, Pond Informer (pondinformer.com), White Flower Farm, Hydrangea.com, Plantura (plantura.garden), Gardenia.net, Old Farmer's Almanac, Hardy Plant Society, Sarah Raven, Wilson Bros Gardens, Garden Design (gardendesign.com), Wayside Gardens, GrowItBuildIt.com, Trehane Nursery, Primrose Hall Peonies, Pomona Fruits, Ashridge Trees, Wildflowers of Ireland (wildflowersofireland.net), Flora of Northern Ireland (habitas.org.uk), BSBI (bsbi.org), First Nature (first-nature.com), British Bryological Society (britishbryologicalsociety.org.uk), Woodland Trust (woodlandtrust.org.uk), Irish Peatland Conservation Council (ipcc.ie).